of the French ancien regime:
It is instructive for [the modern nations 1 to see the ancien regime, which in their countries has experienced its tragedy, play its comic role as a German phantom. Its history was tragic as long as it was the pre-existing power in the world and freedom a personal whim-in a word, as long as it believed, and had to believe, in its own privileges. As long as the ancien regime, as an established world order, was struggling against a world that was only just emerging, there was a world-historical error on its side but not a personal one. Its downfall was therefore tragic.
The present German regime, on the other hand-an anachronism, a flagrant contradiction of universally accepted axioms, the futility of the ancien regime displayed for all the world to see-only imagines that it still believes in itself and asks the world to share in its fantasy. If it believed in its own nature, would it try to hide that nature under the appearance of an alien nature and seek its salvation in hypocrisy and sophism? The modern ancien regime is rather merely the clown of a world order whose real heroes are dead. History is thorough and passes through many stages while bearing an ancient form to its grave. The last phase of a world-historical form is its comedy. The Greek gods, who already died once of their wounds in Aeschylus's tragedy Prometheus Bound, were forced to die a second death-this time a comic one-in Lucian's Dialogues. Why does history take this course? So that mankind may part happily with its past. We lay claim to this happy historical destiny for the political powers of Germany.'
2
Karl Marx. "A Contribution to the Critique of Hegel's Philosophy of Right:' in Early Writings, introduced by Lucio Colletti. Harmondsworth: Penguin 1975. pp. 247 8.

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3
Note the precise characterization of the German ancien regime as the one which "only imagines that it still believes in itself" -one can even speculate about the meaning of the fact that, during the same period, Kierkegaard deployed his idea that we humans cannot ever be sure that we believe: ultimately, we only "believe that we believe:' The formula of a regime which "only imagines that it believes in itself" nicely captures the cancellation of the performative power ("symbolic efficiency") of the ruling ideology: it no longer effectively functions as the fundamental structure of the social bond. And, we may ask, are we not today in the same situation? Do today's preachers and practitioners of liberal democracy not also "only imagine that they believe in themselves:' in their pronunciations? In fact, it would be more appropriate to describe contemporary cynicism as representing an exact inversion of Marx's formula: today, we only imagine that we do not "really believe" in our ideology-in spite of this imaginary distance, we continue to practise it. We believe not less but much more than we imagine we believe. Benjamin was thus indeed prescient in his remark that "everything depends on how one believes in one's belief:'3
Twelve years prior to 9/11, on November 9, 1989, the Berlin Wall fell. This event seemed to announce the beginning of the "happy' 90S:' Francis Fukuyama's utopia of the "end of history," the belief that liberal democracy had, in principle, won out, that the advent of a global liberal community was hovering just around the corner, and that the obstacles to this Hol

mingling with ordinary people, the rich of
Sao Paulo prefer to use helicopters, so that, looking around the skyline of the city, one really does feel as if one is in a futuristic megalopolis of the kind pictured in films such as Blade Runner or The Fifth Element, with ordinary people swarming through the dangerous streets down below, whilst the rich float around on a higher level, up in the air.
It thus seems that Fukuyama's utopia of the 1990S had to die twice, since the collapse of the liberal-democratic political utopia on 9/11 did not affect the economic utopia of global market capitalism; if the 2008 financial meltdown has a historical meaning then, it is as a sign of the end of the economic face of Fukuyama's dream. Which brings us back to Marx's paraphrase of Hegel: one should recall that, in his introduction to a new edition of Eighteenth Brumaire in the 1960s, Herbert Marcuse added yet another turn of the screw: sometimes, the repetition in the guise of a farce can be more terrifying than the original tragedy.
This book takes the ongoing crisis as a starting point, gradually moving to "related matters:' by way of unraveling its conditions and implications. The first chapter offers a diagnosis of our predicament, outlining the utopian core of the capitalist ideology which determined both the crisis itself and our perceptions of and reactions to it. The second chapter endeavors to locate aspects of our situation which open up the space for new forms of communist praxis.

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FIRST AS TRAG E DY. THEN AS FARCE
What the book offers is not a neutral analysis but an engaged and extremely "partial" one-for truth is partial, accessible only when one takes sides, and is no less universal for this reason. The side taken here is, of course, that of communism. Adorno begins his Three Studies on Hegel with a rebuttal of the traditional question about Hegel exemplified by the title of Benedetto Croce's book What Is Living and What Is Dead in the Philosophy of Hegel? Such a question presupposes, on the part of the author, the adoption of an arrogant position as judge of the past; but when we are dealing with a truly great philosopher the real question to be raised concerns not what this philosopher may still tell us, what he may still mean to us, but rather the opposite, namely, what we are, what our contemporary situation might be, in his eyes, how our epoch would appear to his thought. And the same should apply to communism-instead of asking the obvious question "Is the idea of communism still pertinent today, can it still be used as a tool of analysis and political practise?" one should ask the opposite question: "How does our predicament today look from the perspective of the communist idea?" Therein resides the dialectic of the Old and the New: it is those who propose the constant creation of new terms ("postmodern society:' "risk society:' "informational society:' "postindustrial society:' etc.) in order to grasp what is going on today who miss the contours of what is actually New. The only way to grasp the true novelty of the New is to analyze the world through the lenses of what was "eternal" in the Old. If communism really is an "eternal" Idea, then it works as a Hegelian "concrete universality": it is eternal not in the sense of a series of abstract-universal features that may be applied everywhere, but in the sense that it has to be re-invented in each new h

fire to my fully insured but loss-
generating premises)? The same goes for the big banks: are they not protected against big losses and able to keep their profits? No wonder that Michael Moore wrote a letter to the public decrying the bail-out plan as the robbery of the century.
It is this unexpected overlapping of the views of the Left with those of conservative Republicans which should give us pause for thought. What the two perspectives share is their contempt for the big specula-tors and corporate managers who profit from risky decisions but are protected from failures by "golden parachutes:' Recall the cruel joke from Lubitsch's To Be or Not to Be: when asked about the German concentration camps in occupied Poland, the responsible Nazi officer "concentration camp Erhardt" snaps back: "We do the concentrating, and the Poles do the camping:' Does the same not hold for the Enron bankruptcy scandal of January 2002, which can be interpreted as a kind of ironic commentary on the notion of the risk society? Thousands of employees who lost their jobs and savings were certainly exposed to

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risk, but without having had any real choice in the matter-the risk appeared to them as blind fate. On the contrary, those who did have some insight into the risks involved, as well as the power to intervene in the situation (namely, the top managers), minimized their risks by cashing in their stocks and options before the bankruptcy. It is indeed true that we live in a society of risky choices, but it is one in which only some do the choosing, while others do the risking .. .
Is the bail-out plan realy a "socialist" measure then, the birth of state socialism in the US? If it is, it is a very peculiar form: a "socialist" measure whose primary aim is not to help the poor, but the rich, not those who borrow, but those who lend. In a supreme irony, "socializing" the banking system is acceptable when it serves to save capitalism. Socialism is bad-except when it serves to stabilize capitalism. (Note the symmetry with China today: in the same way, the Chinese Communists use capitalism to enforce their "Socialist" regime.)
But what if "moral hazard" is inscribed into the very structure of capitalism? That is to say, there is no way to separate the two: in the capitalist system, welfare on Main Street depends on a thriving Wall Street. So, while Republican populists who resist the bail-out are doing the wrong thing for the right reasons, the proponents of the bail-out are doing the right thing for the wrong reasons. To put it in more sophiS-ticated terms, the relationship is non-transitive: while what is good for Wall Street is not necessarily good for Main Street, Main Street cannot thrive if Wall Street is feeling sickly, and this asymmetry gives an a priori advantage to Wall Street.
Recall the standard "trickle-down" argument against egalitarian redistribution (through high levels of progressive taxation, etc.): instead of making the poor richer, it makes the rich poorer. Far from being simply anti-interventionist, this attitude actually displays a very accurate grasp of economic state intervention: although we all want the poor to become richer, it is counter productive to help them directly, since they are not the dynamic and productive element in society. The only kind of intervention needed is that which helps the rich get richer;

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us socialism" thus becomes ordinary
hard-working people versus the upper-class strata.
But there is nothing new with regard to strong state intervention in the banking system or in the economy in general. The recent meltdown itself is a result of such intervention: when, in 2001, the dotcom bubble (which expressed the very essence of the problem of "intellectual property") burst, it was decided to make credit easier in order to redirect growth into housing. (The ultimate cause of the 2008 meltdown was thus, from this point of view, the deadlock of intellectual property.) And, if we broaden our horizon to encompass global reality, we see that political decisions are weaved into the very texture of international economic relations. A couple of years ago, a CNN report on Mali described the reality of the international "free market:' The two pillars of Mali economy are cotton in the south and cattle in the north, and both are in trouble because of the way Western powers violate the very rules they try to impose on impoverished Third World nations. Mali produces cotton of top quality, but the

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problem is that the financial support the US government gives to its own cotton farmers amounts to more than the entire state budget of Mali, so it is no surprise they cannot compete. In the north, the culprit is the European Union: Malian beef cannot compete with heavily subsidized European milk and beef. The EU subsidizes every single cow with around 500 Euros per year-more than the per capita GDP in Mali. As the Malian minister for the economy put it: we don't need your help or advice or lectures on the beneficial effects of abolishing excessive state regulation; please, just stick to your own rules about the free market and our troubles wil basically be over . . . So where are the Republican defenders of the free market here? The collapse of Mali demonstrates the reality of what it means for the US to put "country firsf'
What all this clearly indicates is that there is no such thing as a neutral market: in every particular situation, market configurations are always regulated by political decisions. The true dilemma is thus not "Should the state intervene?" but "What kind of state intervention is necessary?" And this is matter for real politics: namely, the struggle to define the basic "apolitical" coordinates of our lives. All political issues are in a way non-partisan; they concern the question: "What is our country?" So the debate about the bail-out is precisely true politics, to the extent that it deals with decisions about the fundamental features of our social and economic life, and even, in the process, mobilizes the ghosts of class struggle. There is no "objective;' expert position simply waiting to be applied here; one just has to take one side or the other, politically.
There is a real possibility that the main victim of the ongoing crisis will not be capitalism but the Left itself, insofar as its inability to offer a viable global alternative was again made visible to everyone. It was the Left which was effectively caught out. It is as if recent events were staged with a calculated risk in order to demonstrate that, even at a time of shattering crisis, there is no viable alternative to capitalism.
"Thamzing" is a Tibetan word from the time of Cultural Revolution, with ominous reverberations for liberals: it means a "struggle

void recession a few years ago. The danger
is thus that the predominant narrative of the meltdown wil be the one
which, instead of awakening us from a dream, will enable us to continue
dreaming. And it is here that we should start to worry-not only about
the economic consequences of the meltdown, but about the obvious
temptation to reinvigorate the "war on terror" and US interventionism
in order to keep the motor of the economy running, or at least to use the
crisis to impose further tough measures of "structural adjustment:'
An exemplary case of the way the economic collapse is already being
used in the ideologico-political struggle concerns the conflict over what
to do with General Motors-should the state allow its bankruptcy or
not? Since GM is one of those institutions which embodies the American
dream, its bankruptcy was long considered unthinkable. An increasing
number of voices, however, now refer to the meltdown as providing
that additional nudge which should make us accept the unthinkable. A
New York Times column entitled "Imagining a G.M. Bankruptcy" begins
ominously with: "As General Motors struggles to avoid running out of
cash next year, the once-unthinkable prospect of a G.M. bankruptcy
filing is looking a lot more, well, thinkable:'8 After a series of predictable
arguments (the bankruptcy would not mean automatic job losses, just a
restructuring which would make the company leaner and meaner, better
adapted to the harsh conditions of today's economy, and so on and so
forth) the column dots the 'j's towards the end, when it focuses on the
standotF"between G.M. and its unionized workers and retirees": "Bank-
ruptcy would allow G.M. to unilaterally reject its collective bargaining
agreements, as long as a judge approved:' In other words, bankruptcy
should be used to break the backbone of one of the last strong unions in
8
"Imagining a G.M. bankruptcy," New York Times, December 2, 2008 ("DealBook"
in the Business section).

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the United States, leaving thousands with lower wages and thousands of
others with lower retirement incomes. Note again the contrast with the
urgent need to save the big banks: in the case of GM, where the survival
of tens of thousands of active and retired workers is at stake, there is, of
course, no emergency, but, on the contrary, an opportunity to alow the
free market to operate with brutal force. As if the unions, rather than
failures of managerial strategy, were to be blamed for GM's troubles! This
is how the impossible becomes possible: what was hitherto considered
unthinkable within the horizon of the established standards of decent
working conditions now becomes acceptable.
In his Poverty of Philosophy, Marx wrote that bourgeois ideology
loves to historicize: every social, religious, and cultural form is histor-
ical, contingent, relative-every form except its own. There was history
once, but now there is no longer any history:
Economists have a singular method of procedure. There are only two
kinds of institutions for them, artificial and natural. The institutions of
feudalism are artificial institutions, those of the bourgeOisie are natural
institutions. In this, they resemble the theologians, who likewise establish
two kinds of religion. Every religion which is not theirs is an invention of
men, while their own is an emanation from God. When the economists
say that present-day relations--':the

relations of bourgeoiS production-
are natural, they imply that these are the relations in which wealth is created and productive forces developed in conformity with the laws of nature. These relations therefore are themselves natural laws independent of the influence of time. They are eternal laws which must always govern society. Thus, there has been history, but there is no longer any. There has been history, since there were the institutions of feudalism, and in these institutions of feudalism we find quite different relations of production from those of bourgeois society, which the economists try to pass off as natural and, as such, eternal.9

9
Karl Marx, The Poverty of Philosophy, Chapter 2, "Seventh and last observation;'

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Replace "feudalism" with "socialism" and exactly the same holds true of today's apologists for liberal-democratic capitalism.

No wonder the debate about the limits ofliberal ideology is thriving in France-the reason IS not the long statist tradition which distrusts liberalism; it is rather that the French distance towards the Anglo-Saxon mainstream enables not only a critical stance, but also a clearer perception of the basic ideological structure of liberalism. If one is looking for a clinically pure, laboratory-distilled version of contemporary capitalist ideology, one need only turn to Guy Sorman. The very title of an interview he recently gave in Argentina-"This Crisis Will Be Short Enough"IO-signals that Sorman fulfils the basic demand liberal ideology has to satisfy with regard to the financial meltdown, namely, to renormalize the situation: "things may appear harsh, but the crisis will be short, it is just part of the normal cycle of creative destruction through which capitalism progresses:' Or, as Sorman himself put it in another of his texts, "creative destruction is the engine of economic growth": "This ceaseless replacement of the old with the new-driven by technical innovation and entrepreneurialism, itself encouraged by good economic policies-brings prosperity, though those displaced by the process, who find their jobs made redundant, can understand-

Moscow, Progress Publishers 1955.

And do we not find echoes of the same position in today's discursive "anti essentialist" historicism (from Ernesto Laclau to Judith Butler), which views every social ideological entity as the product of a contingent discursive struggle for hegemony? As it was already noted by Fredric Jameson. universalized historicism has a strange ahistorical flavor: once we fully accept and practise the radical contingency of our identities, all authentic historical tension somehow evaporates in the endless performative games of an eternal present. There is a nice self referential irony at work here: there is history only insofar as there persist remainders of"ahistorical" essentialism. This is why radical anti essentialists have to deploy all their hermeneutic deconstructive skills to detect hidden traces of "essentialism" in what appears to be a postmodern "risk society" of contingencies

were

they to admit that we already live in an "anti essentialist" society, they would have to confront the truly difficult question of the historical character of today's predominant radical historicism itself, i.e., confront the topic of this historicism as the ideological form of "postmodern" global capitalism.

10
"Esta crisis sera bastan

its message is a resigned conviction
that the world we live in, even if not the best of all possible worlds, is
the least bad, such that any radical change will only make things worse.
(As always with effective propaganda, this normalization can easily be
combined with its opposite, reading the economic crisis in religious
terms-Benedict XVI, always sharp when it comes to opportunistic
maneuvering, was expeditious in capitalizing on the financial crisis
along these lines: "This proves that all is vanity, and that only the word
of God holds!") There should thus be no surprise that the financial
meltdown of 2008 also propelled Jacques-Alain Miller to intervene in
such a "constructive" way, to prevent panic:
The monetary Signifier is one of semblance, which rests on social
conventions. The financial universe is an architecture made of fictions
and its keystone is what Lacan called a "subject supposed to know': to
know why and how. Who plays this part? The concert of authorities,
from where sometimes a voice is detached, Alan Greenspan, for example,
in his time. The financial players base their behavior on this. The fictional
and hyper-reflexive unit holds by the "belief" in the authorities, i.e.
through the transference to the subject supposed to know. If this
subject falters, there is a crisis, a falling apart of the foundations, which
of course involves effects of panic. However, the financial subject
supposed to know was already quite subdued because of deregulation.
And this happened because the financial world believed itself, in its
infatuated delusion, to be able to work things out without the function
of the subject supposed to know. Firstly, the real state assets become
waste. S econdly, gradually shit permeates everything. Thirdly, there is
a gigantic negative transfer vis-a.-vis the authorities; the electric shock
of the Paulson/Bernanke plan angers the public: the crisis is one of
trust; and it will last till the subject supposed to know is reconstructed.

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This will come in the long term by way of a new set of Bretton Woods
accords, a council enjoined to speak the truth about the truth.')
Miller's reference point here is Alan Greenspan, the non-partisan
"subject supposed to know" of the long period of economic growth
from the Reagan era till the recent debacle. When, on October 23, 2008,
Greenspan was submitted to a congressional hearing, he conceded
some interesting points in answering his critics who claimed that he
had encouraged the bubble in housing prices by keeping interest rates
too low for too long, and that he had failed to rein in the explosive
growth of risky and often fraudulent mortgage lending.14 Here is the
climactic moment of the hearing, as Representative Henry A. Waxman
of California, Chairman of the Oversight Committee, intervened:
I'm going to interrupt you. The question 1 have for you is, you had an
ideology. This is your statement. "I do have an ideology. My judgment is
that free competitive markets are by far the unrivalled way to organize
economies. We have tried regulation, none meaningfully worked:' That
was your quote. You had the authority to prevent irresponsible lending
practices that led to the subprime15 mortgage crisis. You were advised to
do so by many others. And now our whole economy is paying its price.
Do you feel that your ideology pushed you to make decisions that you
wish you had not mad

:" 7
According to some reports, there are already signs that the scenario described in Atlas Shrugged-of creative capitalists themselves going on strike-is actually coming about. According to John Campbell, a Republican congressman: "The achievers are going on strike. I'm seeing, at a small level, a kind of protest from the people who create jobs . . . who are pulling back from their ambitions because they see how they'll be punished for them:'18 The absurdity of this reaction lies in the fact that it totally misreads the situation: most of the bail-out money is going in gigantic sums to precisely those Randian deregulated "titans" who failed in their "creative" schemes and thereby brought about the downward spiral. It is not the great creative geniuses who are now helping out lazy ordinary people, it is rather the ordinary taxpayers who are helping out the failed "creative geniuses:' One need simply recall that the ideologico-political father of the long economic process which resulted in the meltdown is the aforementioned Alan Greenspan, a card -carrying Randian "objectivist:'
But let us return to Miler, for the message of his weird text is clear: let us wait patiently for the new "subject supposed to know" to emerge. Miler's position here is one of pure liberal cynicism: we al know that the "subject supposed to know" is a transferential ilusion-but we know this "in private;' as psychoanalysts. In public, we should promote the rise of the new "subject supposed to know" in order to control panic reactions . . . Miller has recently been engaged in a struggle against the Europe-wide attempt to impose state regulation of psychoanalysis, which
17
Oliver Burkeman, "Look out for number one; Guardian, March 10, 2.009, p. 3.
18 Ibid.

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would effectively lead to its absorption into the vast field of "scientific" cognitivist and bio-chemical therapies. Unfortunately, he inscribes this struggle in terms of the Right-liberal insistence on the freedom of individuals from socialist and paternalist state control and regulation, referring directly to the work of the pro-Thatcherite neoliberal, Willem H. Buiter.19 What Miler ignores is how the very state regulations he so ferociously opposes are enacted on behalf of the protection of individuals' autonomy and freedom: he is thus fighting the consequences of the very ideology on which he relies. The paradox is that, in today's digitalized society where not only the state but also big companies are able to penetrate and control individual lives to an unheard-of extent, state regulation is needed in order to maintain the very autonomy it is supposed to endanger.
In the middle of April 2009, I was sitting in a hotel room in Syracuse, hopping between two TV programs: a documentary on Pete Seeger, the great American folk singer of the Left, and a Fox News report on the anti-tax "tea party" in Austin, Texas, with a country singer performing an anti-Obama song full of complaints about how Washington is taxing hard-working ordinary people in order to finance the rich Wall Street financiers. The short-circuit between the two programs had an electrifying effect on me, with two especially noticeable features. First, there was the weird similarity between the two musicians, both formulating a populist anti-establishment critique of the exploitative rich and their state, and both calling for
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s of June 2009, voters massively supported
neoconservative-liberal politics-the very politics that brought about
the ongoing crisis. Indeed, who needs direct repression when one can
convince the chicken to walk freely into the slaughterhouse?
Sorman's version of capitalist ideology ignores this process of neces-
sary self-blinding and is, as such, too brutal and blatant to be endorsed
as hegemonic-it has something of the character of "over-identification"
about it, of stating so openly the underlying premises that it becomes
embarrassing to all concerned. Rather, the ideological version of
capitalism which is emerging as hegemonic out of the present crises is
that of a "SOcially responSible" eco-capitalism. While admitting that, in
the past and in the present, the free market system has often been over-
exploitative with catastrophic consequences, the claim is now made
that one can discern the signs of a new orientation which is aware that
the capitalist mobilization of a society's productive capacity can also be
made to serve ecological goals, the struggle against poverty, and other
worthy ends. As a rule, this version is presented as part of a wider shift
towards a new holistic post-materialist spiritual paradigm. With the
growing awareness of the unity of all life on earth and of the common
dangers we all face, a new approach is emerging which no longer
opposes the market to social responsibility-they can be reunited for
mutual benefit. Collaboration with and the participation of employees,
dialogue with customers, respect for the environment, transparency
of business deals, are nowadays the keys to success. Capitalists should
not just be machines for generating profits, since their lives can
have a deeper meaning. Their preferred mottos have become social

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responsibility and gratitude: they are the first to admit that society
has been incredibly good to them by allowing them to deploy their
talents and amass great wealth, so it is their duty to give something
back to society and to help ordinary people. Only this kind of caring
approach makes business success worthwhile . . . The new ethos of
global responsibility is thus able to put capitalism to work as the most
efficient instrument of the common good. The basic ideological dispositif
of capitalism-we can call it "instrumental reason," "technological
exploitation," "individualist greed," or whatever we like-is separated
from its concrete socio-economic conditions (capitalist relations of
production) and conceived of as an autonomous life or "existential"
attitude which should (and can) be overcome by a new more "spiritual"
outlook, leaving these very capitalist relations intact.
Nevertheless, was the financial meltdown of 2008 not a kind of ironic
comment on the ideological nature of this dream of a spiritualized and
SOcially responsible eco-capitalism? As we all know, on December 11,
2008 Bernard Madoff, a highly successful investment manager and
philanthropist from Wall Street, was arrested and charged with alleg-
edly running a $50 billion Ponzi (or pyramid) scheme.
On the surface, Madoff's funds were supposed to be low-risk
investments. His largest fund reported steady returns, usually gaining
a percentage point or two a month. The funds' stated strategy was to
buy large cap stocks and supplement those investments with related
stock-option strategies. The combined investments we

big fetishistic denial:
"I know very well the risks 1 am courting, even the inevitability of the final collapse, but nonetheless , . . [I can put off the collapse a little bit longer, take on a little bit more risk, and so on indefinitely) :' It is a self-blinding "irrationality" strictly correlative to the "irrationality" of the lower classes voting against their own interests, and yet another proof of the material power of ideology. Like love, ideology is blind, even if the people caught up in it are not.
Human, All Too Human . . .
The contemporary era constantly proclaims itself as post-ideological, but this denial of ideology only provides the ultimate proof that we are more than ever embedded in ideology. Ideology is always a field of struggle-among other things, the struggle for appropriating past traditions. One of the clearest indications of our predicament is the liberal appropriation of Martin Luther King, in itself an exemplary ideological operation. Henry Louis Taylor recently remarked: "Everyone
22
Incidentally, it is a sign of the maturity of the US public that there have been no traces of anti-Semitism in their reaction to the financial crisis, although it would have been easy to imagine a reaction such as: "Did you notice how Jews, Jewish financiers, made us hard-working Americans pay $700 billion to cover the costs of their follies!"

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knows, even the smallest kid knows about Martin Luther King, can say his most famous moment was that 'I have a dream' speech. No one can go further than one sentence. Al we know is that this guy had a dream. We don't know what that dream was:'23 King had come a long way from the crowds who cheered him on at the 1963 March on Washington, when he was introduced as "the moral leader of our nation:' By pursuing issues beyond simply that of segregation, he had lost much public support, and was increasingly considered a pariah. As Harvard Sitkoff put it, "he took on issues of poverty and militarism because he considered them vital 'to make equality something real and not just racial brotherhood but equality in fact: " To put it in Badiou's terms, King followed the "axiom of equality" well beyond the single topic of racial segregation: he was campaigning on anti-poverty and anti-war issues at the time of his death. He had spoken out against the Vietnam War, and when he was killed in Memphis in April 1968 he was there in support of striking sanitation workers. As Melissa Harris-Lacewell has put it, "Following King meant following the unpopular road, not the popular one:'
Moreover, all the features we today identify with freedom and liberal democracy (trade unions, the universal vote, free universal education, freedom of the press, etc.) were won through a long and difficult struggle on the part of the lower classes throughout the nineteenth and twentieth centuries-in other words, they were anything but the "natural" consequences of capitalist relations. Recall the list of demands with which The Communist Manifesto concludes: most of them, with the exception of the abolition of private ownership of the means of production, are today widely accepted in "bourgeois" democracies, but only as the result of popular struggles. It is worth underlining another often ignored fact: today, equality between whites and blacks is celebrated as part of the American Dream, and treated as a self-eviden

of the "inner life" and its
"sincere" emotions. The experience we have of our lives from within, the story we tell ourselves about ourselves in order to account for what we are doing, is thus a lie-the truth lies rather outside, in what we do. Therein resides the difficult lesson of Littell's book: in it, we meet someone whose story we do fully hear but who should nonetheless remain our enemy. What is truly unbearable about the Nazi executioners is not so much the terrifying things they did, as how "human, al too human" they remained while doing those things. "Stories we tell ourselves about ourselves" serve to obfuscate the true ethical dimension of our acts. In making ethical judgments, we should be story-blind-this is why Elfriede Jelinek's advice to theatre writers is not only aesthetically correct, but has a deep ethical justification:

Characters on stage should be flat, like clothes in a fashion show: what you get should be no more than what you see. Psychological realism is repulsive, because it allows us to escape unpalatable reality by taking shelter in the "luxuriousness" of personality, lOSing ourselves in the depth of individual character. The writer's task is to block this manoeuvre, to chase us off to a point from which we can view the horror with a dispassionate eye.26

26

Elfriede Jelinek, quoted in Nicholas Spice. "Up from the Cellar." London Review of Books. June 5. 2008. p. 6.

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IT'S IDEOLOGY. STUPID!

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The same strategy of ideological "humanization" (in the sense of the proverbial wisdom "it is human to err") is a key constituent of the ideo-lOgical (self-)presentation of the Israeli Defense Forces (IDF). The Israeli media love to dwell on the imperfections and psychic traumas of the Israeli soldiers, presenting them neither as perfect military machines nor as superhuman heroes, but as ordinary people who, caught up in the traumas of History and warfare, sometimes make errors and lose their way. For example, when in January 2003 the IDF demolished the family home of a suspected "terrorist;' they did so with accentuated kindness, even helping the family to move their furniture out before destroying the house with a buldozer. A similar incident was reported a little bit earlier in the Israeli press: when an Israeli soldier was searching a Palestinian house for suspects, the mother of the family called her daughter by her name in order to calm her down, and the surprised soldier learned that the frightened girl's name was the same as that of his own daughter; in a sentimental outburst, he pulled out his wallet and showed her picture to the Palestinian mother. It is easy to discern the falsity of such a gesture of empathy: the notion that, in spite of political differences, we are all basically human beings with the same loves and worries neutralizes the impact of the activity the soldier was engaged in. As such, the only proper reply of the mother should have been: "If you really are a human being like me, why are you doing what you are doing now?" The soldier could then only have taken refuge in reified duty: "I don't like it, but it is my duty . . ?'-thus avoiding the subjective assumption of his duty.

The point of such humanization is to emphasize the gap between the complex reality of the person and the role he has to play against his true nature. "In my family, our genes are not military;' as one of the soldiers interviewed in Claude La

ackground, were the latter to express
a destructive rage against the Israelis for having reduced him to a paid instrument of the expropriation of his own land? Therein resides the ideo-logical ambiguity of Tsahal: the interviewed soldiers play the role of their "ordinary human selves;' they embody the masks they have constructed to humanize their acts-an ideological mystification that reaches its unsur-passable ironic peak when Ariel Sharon appears as a peaceful farmer.
It is interesting to note how a similar "humanization" process is increasingly present in the recent wave of blockbusters about super-heroes (Spiderman, Batman, Hancock .
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). Critics rave about how these
films move beyond the original flat comic-book characters and dwell in detail over the uncertainties, weaknesses, doubts, fears and anxieties of the supernatural hero, his struggle with his inner demons, his confrontation with his own dark side, and so forth, as if al this makes the commercial super-production somehow more "artistic:' (The exception in this series is M. Night Shyamalan's outstanding Unbreakable.)
In real life, this humanization process undoubtedly reached its apogee in a recent North Korean press release which reported that, at the opening game on the country's first golf course, the beloved
28
Janet Maslin. "Tsahal: Lanzmann's meditation on Israel's defense:' New York Times. January 27. 1995.

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president Kim Jong-II excelled, finishing the entire game of 18 holes in 19 strikes. One can well imagine the reasoning of the propaganda bureaucrat: nobody was going to believe that Kim had managed a hole-in-one every time, so, to make things realistic, let us concede that, just once, he needed two strikes to succeed . . .
Unfortunately, the same kind of "humanization" ruins The Baader Meinhof Complex (2008), the otherwise interesting depiction of the fate of the first -generation Red Army Faction group (Ulrike Meinhof, Gudrun Ensslin, Andreas Baader) in Germany. The subjective standpoint of the film, the position impliCitly offered to the spectator as the point of identification, is that of Meinhof, a "terrorist" who nonetheless remains "human;' beset by fears and doubts, engaged in constant reflection on her predicament, in contrast with Ensslin and Baader who are presented as brutally inhuman in their "angelic" perfection. The gap that separates them appears at its clearest in their respective suicides: Meinhof hangs herself in despair, as her entire ethico-political universe falls apart, while Ensslin and Baader take their own lives as a coldly planned political statement. (In this respect, Meinhof is the counterpoint to the chief police investigator coordinating the hunt for the terrorists, played by Bruno Ganz: in contrast to his colleagues, who just want to exterminate the terrorists, the chief also reflects on the causes of terror and shows consideration for the wider ideologico-political context.)
We should fearlessly extend this insight into the problematic of false "humanization" to the very basic collective form of "telling stories about ourselves;' to the symbolic texture which provides the foundation of a community (ethnic, lifestyle, sexual, religious . . . ). Kant's distinction between the public and private uses of reason can be of great help here: the key problem with forms of so-caled "identity politics" is that they focus on "pr

there is a clinical lesson to be learned about parenthood,
it is that there can be no clean, non-toxic parent: some libidinal dirt
will always stain the ideal parental figure. And one should push this
generalization to the end: what is toxic is ultimately the Neighbor as
such, the abyss of its desire and its obscene enjoyment. The ultimate
aim of all rules governing interpersonal relations, then, is to quarantine
or neutralize this toxic dimension, to reduce the Neighbor to a fellow
man. It is thus not enough to search for contingent toxic components
in (another) subject, for the subject as such is toxic in its very form, in
its abyss of Otherness-what makes it toxic is the objet petit a on which
the subject's consistency hinges. When we think we really know a close
friend or relative, it often happens that, all of a sudden, this person does
something-utters an unexpectedly vulgar or cruel remark, makes an
obscene gesture, casts a cold indifferent glance where compassion was
expected-which makes us aware that we do not really know them; we
become conscious of a total stranger in front of us. At this point, the
fellow man changes into a Neighbor.
As if in an ironic nod to Giorgio Agamben's theory of the state of excep-
tion, in July 2008 the Italian government proclaimed a state of emergency
throughout Italy in order to cope with the problem of the Neighbor in
its paradigmatic contemporary form: the illegal entry of immigrants
from North Africa and Eastern Europe. Taking a demonstrative step
further in this direction, at the beginning of August, it deployed 4,000
armed soldiers to control sensitive points in big cities (train stations,

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commercial centers . . . ) and thus raise the level of public security.
There are also now plans to use the military to protect women from
rapists. What is important to note here is that the emergency state was
introduced without any great fuss: life goes on as normal . . . Is this not
the state we are approaching in developed countries around the globe,
where this or that form of the emergency state (deployed against the
terrorist threat, against immigrants, and so on) is simply accepted as a
measure necessary to guarantee the normal run of things?
So what is the reality of this emergency state? An incident on September
20, 2oo7-when seven Tunisian fishermen went on trial in Sicily for the
crime of rescuing forty-four African migrants from certain death in
the sea-will make it clear. If convicted for "aiding and abetting ilegal
immigrants;' they faced between one and fifteen years in jail. On August 7,
the fishermen had dropped anchor on a shelf 30 miles south of the island
of Lampedusa near Sicily, and falen sleep. Awakened by screams, they
saw a rubber boat crammed with starving people, including women and
children, wallowing in the rough waves and on the point of sinking. The
captain decided to bring them to the nearest port on Lampedusa, where
he and his entire crew were then arrested. Al observers agree that the
true goal of this absurd trial is to dissuade other boat crews from doing
the same thing: no action was taken against other fishermen who, when
they found themselves in a similar situation, were reported as having
beaten the migrants away with sticks, letting them drown.)l What this
incident demonstrates is that Agamben's notion of homo sacer, the one
excluded from the civil order who can

" from civil society, it presents itself as the
ideal sphere of the citoyen in contrast to the conflict of selfish interests that characterize the bourgeois. Berlusconi has effectively abolished this alienation: in contemporary Italy, state power is exercised directly by the base bourgeois who ruthlessly and openly exploits state power as a way of protecting his economic interests, and who washes the dirty laundry of his private marriage problems in the style of a vulgar reality show in front of millions watching on their TV screens.
The last genuinely tragic US president was Richard Nixon. As two outstanding films about him (Oliver Stone's Nixon and the recent Frost/ Nixon) demonstrate, he was a crook, but a crook who fell victim to the gap between his ideals and ambitions and the reality of his acts, and who thus experienced an authentically tragic downfall. With Ronald Reagan (and Carlos Menem in Argentina), a different figure of the president entered the stage, a "Teflon" president whom one is tempted to characterize as post-Oedipal: a "postmodern" president who, being no longer even expected to stick conSistently to his electoral program, has thus become impervious to criticism (recall how Reagan's popularity went up after every public appearance, when journalists enumerated his mistakes). This new kind of preSident mixes (what appear to be) spontaneously naive outbursts with the most ruthless manipulation.
The wager of Berlusconi's indecent vulgarities is, of course, that the

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people wil identify with him insofar as he embodies or enacts the mythical image of the average Italian: "I am one of you, a little bit corrupt, in trouble with the law, I fall out with my wife because I am attracted by other women . . :' Even his grandiose enactment of a noble politician, II Cavaliere, is more like a ridiculously operatic poor man's dream of greatness. And yet, this appearance of his being "just an ordinary guy like the rest of us" should not deceive us: beneath the clownish mask there is a mastery of state power functioning with ruthless efficiency. Even if Berlusconi is a clown without dignity, we should therefore not laugh at him too much-perhaps, by doing so, we are already playing his game. His laughter is more like the obscene-crazy laughter of the superhero's enemy from a Batman or Spiderman movie. To get an idea of the nature of his rule, one should imagine something like the Joker from Batman in power. The problem is that technocratic administration combined with a clownish fa<;:ade do not themselves suffice: something more is needed, namely-fear. Here enters Berlusconi's two-headed beast, consisting of the immigrants and the "Communists" (Berlusconi's generic name for anyone who attacks him, inclusive of the British right-of-center liberal journal, The Economist).
Oriana Fallaci (who was otherwise rather sympathetic towards Berlusconi) once wrote: "True power does not need arrogance, a long beard and a barking voice. True power strangles you with silk ribbons, charm, and intelligence:' In order to understand Berlusconi, one has only to add to this series a talent for stupid self-mockery. Kung Fu Panda, the 2008 cartoon film hit, provides the basic coordinates of the functioning of contemporary ideology. The fat panda bear dreams of becoming a sacred Kung Fu warrior, and when, through blind chance (beneath which, of co

life (from the very beginning, Starbucks presented its coffee shops as an ersatz community). And if this is not enough, if your ethical needs are still unsatisfied and you continue to worry about Third World misery, then there are additional products you can buy. Here is the Starbucks description of their "Ethos Water" program:

Ethos Water is a brand with a social mission -helping children around the world get clean water and raising awareness of the World Water Crisis. Every time you purchase a bottle of EthosW water. Ethos Water will contribute US $0.05 (C$0.10 in Canada) toward our goal of raising at least US $10 million by 2010. Through The Starbucks Foundation, Ethos Water supports humanitarian water programs in Africa, Asia and Latin America. To date, Ethos Water grant commitments exceed $6.2 million . These programs will help an estimated 420,000 people gain access to safe water, sanitation and hygiene education.3!

(No mention here of the fact that a bottle of Ethos Water is 5 cents more expensive in Starbucks than in other similar places . . . ) This is how capitalism, at the level of consumption, integrated the legacy of'68, the critique of alienated consumption: authentic experience matters. A recent Hilton Hotels publicity campaign consists of a simple claim: "Travel doesn't only get us from place A to place B. It should also make us a better person:' Only a decade ago, could one have imagined such an ad appearing? Is this not also the reason we buy organic food? Who really believes that half-rotten and overpriced "organic" apples are really healthier than the non-organic varieties? The point is that, in buying them, we are not merely buying and consuming, we are simultaneously doing something meaningful, shOWing our capacity for care and our global awareness, participating in a collective project . . . The latest scientific expression of this "new spirit" is the rise of a new discipline: "happiness studies:' How is it, however, that in our era of spiritualized hedonism, when the goal oflife

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Quoted from http://ww.starbucks.com.

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is directly defined as happiness, the number of people suffering from anxiety and depression is exploding? It is the enigma of this self-sabotaging of happiness and pleasure which makes Freud's message more pertinent than ever.

As is often the case, a developing Third World country, namely Bhutan, naively spells out the absurd socio-political consequences of this notion of happiness. Already a decade ago, the kingdom of Bhutan decided to focus on measuring Gross National Happiness (GNH) rather than Gross National Product (GNP); the idea was the brainchild of ex-king Jigme Singye Wangchuck, who sought to steer Bhutan into the modern world while preserving its unique identity. With the pressures of globalization and materialism mounting, and the tiny country set for its first ever elections, the immensely popular Oxford-educated new king, 27-year-old Jigme Khesar Namgyel Wangchuck, ordered a state agency to calculate how happy the kingdom's 670,000 people really are. Officials said they had already conducted a survey of around 1,000 people and drawn up a list of parameters for being happy (similar to the development index, tracked by the United Nations). The main concerns were identified as psychological well-being, health, education, good governance, living

aintliness, up to and including
the liberal -communist entrepreneurial spirit of working for the good of
all . A couple of years ago, even a high Vatican representative proclaimed
that the celebration of Che is to be understood as expressing admiration
for a man who risked and gave his life for the good of others. As usually,
harmless beatification is mixed with its opposite, obscene commodifi-
cation-an Australian company recently marketed a "Cherry Guevara"
ice cream, focusing its promotion on the "eating experience;' of course:
"The revolutionary struggle of the cherries was squashed as they
were trapped between two layers of chocolate. May their memory
live in your mouth!"40 There is nonetheless something desperate in this
insistence that Che has become a neutral commodity logO-witness
the series of recent publications warning us that he was also a cold-
blooded murderer who orchestrated the purges in Cuba in 1959, and
so forth . Significantly, these warnings popped up precisely as new anti-
capitalist rebellions began to take place all around the world, making
his icon potentially dangerous again. Under the title "Polish Minister
Wants Ban on Lenin, Guevara T-Shirts:' Europe News reported on
April 23, 2009 that "Poland's equality minister wants to expand a ban
on fascist or totalitarian propaganda to include books, clothing and
other items":
Minister Elzbieta Radziszewska wants to widen a law that prohibits
producing fascist or totalitarian propaganda. The legislation would
prohibit images of Che Guevara, popular across the world on t-shirts,
posters and murals. "I support such a solution," Professor WOjciech
Roszkowski told the daily Rzeczpospolita. "Communism was a terrible,
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See Michael Glover, "The marketing of a Marxist; Times (London), June 6, 2006.

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murderous system, responsible for a million victims. It's very similar to
National Socialism. There's no reason to treat the systems-and their
symbols -any differently:'
What survived of the sexual liberation of the 1960s was a tolerant
hedonism easily incorporated into our hegemonic ideology standing
under the aegis of the superego. So what is the superego? On the
information sheet in a New York hotel, I recently read: "Dear guest!
To guarantee that you will fully enjoy your stay with us, this hotel is
totally smoke-free. For any infringement of this regulation, you will be
charged $200:' The beauty of this formulation, taken literally, is that you
are to be punished for refUSing to fully enjoy your stay . . . The superego
imperative to enjoy thus functions as the reversal of Kant's "Du kannst,
denn du soUstf" (You can, because you must!); it relies on a "You must,
because you can!" That is to say, the superego aspect of today's "non-
repressive" hedonism (the constant provocation we are exposed to,
enjoining us to go right to the end and explore all modes ofjouissance)
resides in the way permitted jouissance necessarily turns into obliga-
tory jouissance. This drive to pure autistic jouissance (through drugs
or other trance-inducing means) arose at a precise political moment:
when the emancipatory sequence of 1968 had exhausted its potential.
At this critical point (the mid-1970S), the only option left was a direct,
brutal, passage a l'acte, a push-towards-the-Real, which assumed three
main forms: the search for extreme forms of sexual jouissance; Leftist
political te

er and control), Lacan
"poses, for the modern age, disjunction, tearing, discord between knowl-
edge and power . . . . The diagnostic that Lacan poses for the malaise of
civilization is that knowledge has assumed 'a disproportionate growth in
relationship to the effects of power: "45 In the fall of 2007, a public debate
raged in the Czech Republic concerning the installation of US Army
radars on Czech territory; although a large majority of the population
(around 70 percent) was opposed to it, the government pushed on with
the project. Government representatives rejected calls for a referendum,
arguing that one does not make decisions about such sensitive national
security matters merely by voting-they should be left to the military
experts.46 If one follows this logic through to the end, one arrives at a
strange result: what is there, then, left to vote about? Should not economic
decisions, for example, be left to economic experts, and so on for all other
realms?
This situation presents us with the deadlock of the contemporary
"society of choice" in its most radical form. There are multiple ideolog-
ical investments in the topic of choice today, even though brain scientists
point out that freedom of choice is an ilusion-we experience ourselves
as "free" simply when we are able to act in the way our organism has
determined, with no external obstacles to thwart our inner prop en-
sitiesY Liberal economists emphasize freedom of choice as the key
ingredient of the market economy: by buying things we are, in a certain
way, continuously voting with our money. "Deeper" existential thinkers
45
Ibid.
46
Interestingly, the same representatives evoked a purely political reason for the
decision: the US had helped the Czechs to achieve freedom three times in their history
(in 1918, 1945, and 1989), so the Czechs should now return the favor by denying themselves
this very freedom . . .
47
Recent research has already moved much further than Benjamin Libel's classic
experiments from the 1980s, which demonstrated that our brain makes a decision around
three tenths of a second before the brain's owner becomes aware of it. By measuring brain
activity during a complex problem solving exercise, one can establish that the volunteer
will have the magical momentary insight that solves the problem a full ten seconds before
the insight actually occurs to him. See "Incognito:' Economist, April 18 24, 2009, pp. 78 9.

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like to deploy variations on the theme of the "authentic" existential choice,
where the very core of our being is at stake-a choice which involves a full
existential engagement, as opposed to the superficial choices of this or
that commodity. In the "Marxist" version of this theme, the multiplicity
of choices with which the market bombards us only serves to obfuscate
the absence of any really radical choice concerning the fundamental
structure of our society. There is, however, a feature conspicuously
missing from this series: namely, the injunction to choose when we
lack the basic cognitive coordinates needed to make a rational choice.
As Leonardo Padura puts it: "It is horrific not to know the past and yet
be able to impact on the future" ;48 being compelled to make decisions
in a situation which remains opaque is our basic condition. We know
the standard situation of the forced choice in which I am free to choose
on condition that I make the righ

t choice, so that the only thing left
for me to do is make the empty gesture of pretending to accomplish freely what expert knowledge has imposed upon me. But what if, on the contrary, the choice really is free and, for this very reason, is experienced as even more frustrating? We thus find ourselves constantly in the position of having to decide about matters that will fundamentally affect our lives, but without a proper foundation in knowledge. To quote John Gray again: "we have been thrown into a time in which everything is provisional. Newtechnologies alter our lives daily. The traditions of the past cannot be retrieved. At the same time we have little idea of what the future will bring. We are forced to live as if we were jree:'[49]
The incessant pressure to choose involves not only ignorance about the object of choice, but, even more radically, the subjective impossibility of answering the question of desire. When Lacan defines the object of desire as originally lost, his point is not simply that we never know what we desire and are condemned to an eternal search for the

48
Leonardo Padura, Havana Gold, London: Bitter Lemon Press 2008, pp. 233
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49
Gray, Straw Dogs. p. 110.

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"true" object, which is the void of desire as such, while all positive objects are merely its metonymic stand-ins. His point is a much more radical one: the lost object is ultimately the subject itself, the subject as an object; which means that the question of desire, its original enigma, is not primarily "What do I want?" but "What do others want from me? What object-objet a-do they see in me?" Which is why, apropos the hysterical question "Why am I that name?" (Le., where does my symbolic identity originate, what justifies it?), Lacan points out that the subject as such is hysterical. He defines the subject tautologically as "that which is not an object:' the point being that the impossibility of identifying oneself as an object (that is, of knowing what I am libidinally for others) is constitutive of the subject. In this way, Lacan generates the entire diversity of "pathological" subjective positions, reading it as the diversity of the answers to the hysterical question: the hysteric and the obsessive enact two modalities of the question-the psychotic knows itself as the object of the Other's jouissance, while the pervert posits itself as the instrument of the Other's jouissance.
Herein resides the terrorizing dimension of the pressure to choose-what resonates even in the most innocent inquiry when one reserves a hotel room ("Soft or hard pilows? Double or twin beds?") is the much more radical probing: "Tell me who you are? What kind of an object do you want to be? What would fil in the gap of your desire?" This is why the "anti-essentialist" Foucauldian apprehension about "fixed identities" -the incessant urge to practise the "care of the Self,' to continuously re-invent and re-create oneself-finds a strange echo in the dynamics of "postmodern" capitalism. Of course, good old existentialism had already claimed that man is what he makes of himself, and had linked this radical freedom to existential anxiety. Here the anxiety of experiencing one's freedom, the lack of one's substantial determination, was the authentic moment at which the subject's integration into the fixity of its ideological universe is shattered. But what existentialism was

on the one hand its role may remain unconscious; on the other, one may think that the fetish is what really matters, as in the case of the Western Buddhist unaware that the "truth" of his existence lies in the very social relations he tends to dismiss as a mere game.

Another distinction between two different modes of fetishism is even more important: the aforementioned permissive-cynical fetishism should be opposed to populist-fascistic fetishism. Let us explain this former mode by, once again, opposing the ideological mystification it involves to populist-fascistic mystification. The first involves a false universality: the subject advocates freedom or equality, while being unaware of implicit qualifications which, in their very form, constrain its scope (the privileging of certain social strata: being rich, or male, or belonging to a certain culture, etc.). The second involves a false identification of both the nature of the antagonism and the enemy: class struggle is displaced, for instance, onto the struggle against the Jews, so that popular rage at being explOited is redirected away from capitalist relations as such and onto the "Jewish plot:' So, to put it in naively hermeneutic terms, in the first case, "when the subject says 'freedom

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and equality: he really means 'freedom of trade, equality before the law: etc:'; and in the second case, "when the subject says 'Jews are the cause of our misery: he really means 'big capital is the cause of our misery: "

The asymmetry is clear. To put it again in naive terms: in the first case, the explicit "good" content (freedom/equality) covers up the implicit "bad" content (class and other privileges and exclusions), while in the second case, the explicit"bad" content (anti-Semitism) covers over the implicit "good" content (class struggle, hatred of exploitation).

As we can clearly see, the inner structure of these two ideological mystifications is again that of the couple symptomlJetish: the implicit limitations (on freedom/equality) are the symptoms of liberal egalitarianism (singular returns of the repressed truth), whilst the "Jew" is the fetish of anti-Semitic fascists (the "last thing the subject sees" before confronting class struggle). This asymmetry has crucial consequences for the critico-ideological process of demystification: apropos liberal egalitarianism, it is not enough to make the old Marxist point about the gap between the ideological appearance of the universal legal form and the particular interests that effectively sustain it, as is so common among politically correct critics on the Left. The counter-argument that the form is never a "mere form:' but has a dynamic of its own which leaves traces in the materiality of social life, as developed by theoreticians such as Claude Leforpo and Jacques Ranciere,51 is fully valid-it was bourgeois "formal freedom" which set in motion the process of "material" political demands and practises, from trade unionism to feminism. One should resist the cynical temptation of reducing it to a mere illusion concealing a different actuality; this would be to fall into the trap of the old Stalinist hypocrisy which mocked "merely formal" bourgeois freedom-if it was so merely formal as to be incapable of disturbing the true power relations, why then did the Stalinist regime not allow such freedom? Why was it so afraid of it?

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See Claude Lefor

t, The Political Forms of Modern Society: Bureaucracy,
Democracy, Totalitarianism, Cambridge: MIT Press 1986.
51 See Jacques Ranciere, Hatred of Democracy, London: Verso Books 2007.

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The interpretive demystification is here thus relatively easy, since it mobilizes the tension between form and content: to be consistent, an "honest" liberal democrat wil have to admit that the content of his ideological premise belies its form, and thus wil radicalize the form (the egalitarian axiom) by way of implementing the content more thoroughly. (The main alternative is the retreat into cynicism: "we know egalitarianism is an impossible dream, so let us pretend that we are egalitarians, while silently accepting the necessary limitations . . :')
In the case of the "Jew" as the fascistic fetish, the interpretive demystification is much more difficult (thereby confirming the clinical insight that a fetishist cannot be undermined with an interpretation of the "meaning" of his fetish-fetishists feel satisfied in their fetishes, they experience no need to be rid of them). In practical political terms, this means that it is almost impossible to "enlighten" an exploited worker who blames "the Jews" for his misery-explaining to him how the "Jew" is the wrong enemy, promoted by his true enemy (the ruling class) in order to obscure the true struggle-and thus to direct his attention away from "Jews" and towards "capitalists:' (Even empirically, while many communists jOined the Nazis in Germany in the 1920S and 1930S, and while many disappointed communist voters in France over the last few decades have turned to Le Pen's National Front, the opposite process has been extremely rare.) To put it in crude political terms, the paradox is thus that, while the subject of the first mystification is primarily the enemy (the liberal "bourgeois" who thinks he is fighting for universal equality and freedom), and while the subjects of the second mystification are primarily "our own' (the underprivileged themselves, who are seduced into directing their rage at the wrong target), effective and practical "demystification" is much easier in the first case than in the second.
The contemporary hegemonic ideological scene is thus split between these two modes of fetishism, the cynical and the fundamentalist, both impervious to "rational" argumentative criticism. While the fundamentalist ignores (or at least mistrusts) argumentation, blindly clinging to his fetish, the cynic pretends to accept argumentation, but ignores its

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symbolic efficiency. In other words, while the fundamentalist (not so much believes as) directly "knows" the truth embodied in his fetish, the cynic practises the logic of disavowal ("I know very well, but . . :'). We can thus construct a matrix consisting of four positions (or attitudes towards ideology): (1) liberal, (2) cynical fetishist, (3) fundamentalist fetishist; (4) ideologico-critical. Unsurprisingly, they form a Greimasian semiotic square in which the four positions are distributed along two axes: symptom versus fetish; identification versus distance. Both the liberal and the critic-of-ideology move at the symptomal level: the first is caught up in it, the second undermines it by way of interpretive analysis. Both the populist fetishist and the cynic cling to their fetish: the first di

rectly,
the second in a disavowed manner. Both the populist fetishist and the liberal directly identify with their position (clinging to their fetish; taking seriously the arguments for their universal ideological claims), while both the cynic and the critic-of-ideology distance themselves from their position (fetishistic disavowal or critical interpretation).
With regard to ideological struggle then, this means that one should at least view with profound suspicion those Leftists who argue that the Muslim fundamentalist-populist movements, as emancipatory and anti-imperialist, are basically "on our side;' and that the fact that they formulate their programs in directly anti-Enlightenment and anti-universalistic terms, sometimes approaching explicit anti-Semitism, is no more than a confusion resulting from their being caught up into the immediacy of struggle. ("When they say they are against the Jews, what they really mean is only that they are against Zionist colonialism:')
One should unconditionally resist the temptation to "understand" Arab anti-Semitism (where we really encounter it) as a "natural" reaction to the sad plight of the Palestinians: there should be no "understanding" of the fact that in several Arab countries Hitler is still considered a hero by many, or of the fact that in their primary school textbooks all the traditional anti-Semitic myths are recycled, from the notorious forgery The Protocols of the Elders of Zion to the idea that Jews use the blood of Christian (or Arab) children for sacrificial purposes. To

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claim that such anti-Semitism articulates in a displaced mode a form of resistance to capitalism in no way justifies it: displacement is here not a secondary operation, but the fundamental gesture of ideological mystification. What this claim does involve, however, is the idea that in the long term the only way to fight anti-Semitism is not to preach liberal tolerance and the like, but to articulate its underlying anti-capitalist motivation in a direct and non-displaced way. To accept the aforementioned erroneous logic of fundamentalism is to take the first step on a path towards the quite "logical" conclusion that, since Hitler also "really meant" capitalists when he spoke of "Jews:' he should be our strategic ally in the global anti-imperialist struggle, with the Anglo-American empire as the principal enemy. (And this line of reasoning is not a mere rhetorical exercise: the Nazis did promote anti-colonialist struggle in Arab countries and in India, and many neo-Nazis do sympathize with the Arab struggle against the State of Israel.)52 It would be a fatal mistake to think that, at some point in the future, we will convince the fascists that their "real" enemy is capital, and that they should drop the particular religious/ ethnic/racist form of their ideology in order to join forces with egalitarian universalism.
Thus one should clearly reject the dangerous motto "the enemy of my enemy is my friend;' which leads us to discern "progressive" anti-imperialist potential in fundamentalist Islamist movements. The ideological universe of organizations like Hezbollah is based on the blurring of distinctions between capitalist neo-imperialism and secular progressive emancipation: within the ideological space of Hezbollah, women's emancipation, gay rights, and so on, are nothing but "decadent" moral aspects o

ear genuine
criticism of the Obama administration which is far more dangerous
than the Bush administration both because it is being given such a free
hand and because it is a far stronger administration.
The ideological bias in the New York Times article is discernible in how it
speaks of the Taliban's "ability to exploit class divisions;' as if the Taliban's
"true" agenda lies elsewhere-in religiOUS fundamentalism-and they
are merely "taking advantage" of the plight of the poor landless farmers.
To this, one should simply add two things. First, this distinction between
the "true" agenda and the instrumental manipulation is an externally
imposed one: as if the poor landless farmers themselves do not
experience their plight in "fundamentalist religious" terms! Second, ifby
"taking advantage" of the farmers' plight the Taliban are "raising alarm
about the risks to Pakistan, which remains largely feudal;' what prevents
liberal democrats in Pakistan as well as in the US from similarly "taking
advantage" of the situation and trying to help the landless farmers? The
sad truth behind the fact that this obvious question is not raised in the
53
Jane Perlez and Pir Zubair Shah, "Taliban exploit class rifts to gain ground in
Pakistan;' New York Times. April 16. 2009.
54
Thomas Altizer, quoted from personal communication.

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New York Times report is that the feudal forces in Pakistan are them-
selves the "natural ally" of liberal democracy . . .
One of the political consequences of this paradoxical situation is
the properly dialectical tension between long-term strategy and short-
term tactical alliances. Although, in the long term, the success of the
radical emancipatory struggle depends on mobilizing the lower classes
who are today often in thrall to fundamentalist populism, one should
have no qualms about concluding short-term alliances with egalitarian
liberals as part of the anti-sexist and anti-racist struggle.
What phenomena such as the rise of the Taliban demonstrate is that
Walter Benjamin's old thesis that "every rise of Fascism bears witness to
a failed revolution" not only still holds true today, but is perhaps more
pertinent than ever. Liberals like to point out similarities between
Left and Right "extremisms": Hitler's terror and death camps imitated
Bolshevik terror and the Gulags; the Leninist form of the party is kept
alive today in al-Qaeda-yes, but what does all this mean? It can also
be read as an indication of how fascism literally replaces (takes the
place of) Leftist revolution: its rise is the Left's failure, but simultane-
ously a proof that there was a revolutionary potential, a dissatisfaction,
which the Left was not able to mobilize. And does the same not hold
for so-called "Islamo-Fascism"? Is the rise of radical Islamism not
exactly correlative to the disappearance of the secular Left in Muslim
countries? Today, when Afghanistan is portrayed as the epitome of
a fundamentalist Islamist country, who still remembers that, only 30
years ago, it was a country with strong secular tradition, including a
powerful Communist Party which took power independently of the
Soviet Union? Where did this secular tradition go? In Europe, exactly
the same goes for Bosnia: back in the 1970S and 1980s, Bosnia and
Herzegovina was (multi)culturally the most interesting and lively of all
Yugoslav republics, with an internationally recognized cin

iou's motto "mieux vaut un desastre qu'un desetre": one has to take the risk of fidelity to an Event, even if the Event ends up in an "obscure disaster?' The best indicator of the Left's lack of trust in itself is its fear of crisis; such a Left fears for its own comfortable position as a critical voice fully integrated into the system, ready to risk nothing. Which is why today, more than ever, Mao Zedong's old motto is pertinent: "Everything under heaven is in utter chaos; the situation is excellent:'

A true Left takes a crisis seriously, without illusions, but as something inevitable, as a chance to be fully exploited. The basic insight of the radical Left is that although crises are painful and dangerous they are ineluctable, and that they are the terrain on which battles have to be waged and won. The difference between liberalism and the radical Left is that, although they refer to the same three elements (liberal center, populist Right, radical Left), they locate them in a radically different topology: for the liberal center, the radical Left and the Right are two forms of the same "totalitarian" excess; while for the Left, the only true alternative is the one between itself and the liberal mainstream, the populist "radical" Right being nothing but the symptom of liberalism's inability to deal with the Leftist threat. When today we hear a politician or an ideologist offering us a choice between liberal freedom and fundamentalist oppression, triumphantly asking (purely rhetorical)

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questions such as "Do you want women to be excluded from public life and deprived of their elementary rights? Do you want every critic or mocker of religion to be punishable by death?" what should make us suspicious is the very self-evidence of the answer-who would have wanted that? The problem is that such a simplistic liberal universalism long ago lost its innocence. This is why, for a true Leftist, the conflict between liberal permissiveness and fundamentalism is ultimately a false conflict-a vicious cycle in which two opposed poles generate and presuppose each other. Here one should take an Hegelian step backwards, placing in question the very measure from which fundamentalism appears in all its horror. Liberals have long ago lost their right to judge. What Horkheimer once said should also be applied to today's fundamentalism: those who do not want to talk (critically) about liberal democracy and its noble principles should also keep quiet about religiOUS fundamentalism. And, even more pointedly, one should emphatically insist that the conflict between the State of Israel and the Arabs is a false conflict: even if we will all come to perish because of it, it is a conflict which only mystifies the true issues.

How are we to understand this reversal of an emancipatory thrust into fundamentalist populism? In authentic Marxism, totality is not an ideal, but a critical notion-to locate a phenomenon in its totality does not mean to see the hidden harmony of the Whole, but to include within a system al its "symptoms:' it antagonisms and inconsistencies, as integral parts. In this sense then, liberalism and fundamentalism form a "totality:' for their opposition is structured so that liberalism itself generates its opposite. Where then do the core values ofliberalism-freedom, equality, etc.-stand? The paradox is that liberalism itself is not stron

on on reformist gradualism also leads us on to the limits
of political cynicism. There is one thing about Henry Kissinger, the
ultimate cynical Realpolitiker, which cannot but strike all observers:
namely, how utterly wrong al his predictions have been. For example,
when news reached the West about the anti-Gorbachev military
coup of 1991, Kissinger immediately accepted the new regime (which
ignominiously collapsed three days later) as a fact-in short, when the
socialist regimes were already in a state of living death, he was counting
on a long-term pact with them. What this example perfectly demon-
strates is the limitation of the cynical attitude: cynics are les non-dupes
who errent; what they fail to recognize is the symbolic efficacy of illusions,
the way they regulate activity which generates social reality. The position
of cynicism is that of popular wisdom-the paradigmatic cynic tells you
privately, in a confidential low-key voice: "But don't you get it? That it
is all really about [money, power, sex .
. . J, that all high principles and
values are just empty phrases which count for nothing?" In this sense,
philosophers effectively "believe in the power of ideas:' they believe that
"ideas rule the world:' and cynics are fully justified in accusing them of
55
John Caputo and Gianni Vattimo, After the Death of God, New York: Columbia
University Press 2007. pp. 124 5.

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this sin. What the cynics do not recognize, however, is their own naivete.
It is the philosophers who are the true realists: they are well aware that
the cynical position is impossible and inconsistent, that cynics effectively
follow the principles they publicly mock. Stalin was a cynic if there ever
was one-but precisely as such, he sincerely believed in communism.
After denouncing al the "usual suspects" for utopianism then, perhaps
the time has come to focus on the liberal utopia itself. lhis is how one
should answer those who dismiss any attempt to question the fundamentals
of the liberal-democratic-capitalist order as being themselves dangerously
utopian: what we are confronting in today's crisis are the consequences of
the utopian core of this order itself While liberalism presents itself as anti-
utopianism embodied, and the triumph of neoliberalism as a sign that we
have left behind the utopian projects responsible for the totalitarian horrors
of the twentieth century, it is now becoming clear that the true utopian
epoch was that of the happy Clintonite '90S, with its belief that we had
reached the "end of history:' that humanity had finally found the formula
for the optimal socio-economic order. But the experience of recent decades
clearly shows that the market is not a benign mechanism which best works
when left to its own devices-it requires a good deal of extra-market
violence to establish and maintain the conditions for its functioning.
The ongoing financial meltdown demonstrates how difficult it is to
disturb the thick undergrowth of utopian premises which determine
our acts. As Alain Badiou SUCcinctly put it:
The ordinary citizen must "understand" that it is impossible to make up
the shortfall in social security, but that it is imperative to stuff untold
billions into the banks' financial hole? We must somberly accept that
no one imagines any longer that it's possible to nationalize a factory
hounded by competition, a factory employing thousands of workers

ve end
of the epoch which began with the October Revolution. One should therefore reject any sense of continuity with what the Left meant over the last two centuries. Although sublime moments like the Jacobin climax of the French Revolution and the October Revolution will forever remain a key part of our memory, the general framework has to be surpassed, and everything should be re-thought, beginning from the zero-point. This beginning is, of course, what Badiou calls "the communist hypothesis" :

The communist hypothesis remains the right hypothesis, as I have said, and I do not see any other. If this hypothesis should have to be abandoned, then it is not worth doing anything in the order of collective action . Without the perspective of communism, without this Idea, nothing in the historical and political future is of such a kind as to interest the philosopher. Each individual can pursue their private business, and we won't mention it again . . . . But holding on to the Idea, the existence of the hypothesis, does not mean that its first form of presentation, focused on property and the state, must be maintained just as it is. In fact, what we are ascribed as a philosophical task, we could say even a duty, is to help a new modality of existence of the hypothesis to come into being. New in terms of the type of political experimentation to which this hypothesis could give rise.>

One should be careful not to read these lines in a Kantian way, conceiving communism as a "regulative Idea:' thereby resuscitating the specter of an "ethical socialism" taking equality as its a priori norm-axiom. One should rather maintain the precise reference to a set of actual social

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Alain Badiou, The Meaning of Sarkozy, London: Verso 2008, p. II5.

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antagonisms which generates the need for communism-Marx's notion of communism not as an ideal, but as a movement which reacts to such antagonisms, is still fuly relevant. However, if we conceive of communism as an "eternal Idea:' this implies that the situation which generates it is no less eternal, i.e., that the antagonism to which communism reacts wil always exist. And from here, it is only one small step to a "deconstructive" reading of communism as a dream of presence, of abolishing all alienated re-presentation, a dream which thrives on its own impossibility. How then are we to break out of this formalism in order to formulate antagonisms which will continue to generate the communist Idea? Where are we to look for this Idea's new mode?

It is easy to make fun of Fukuyama's notion of the "End of History:' but most people today are Fukuyamean, accepting liberal-democratic capitalism as the finally found formula of the best possible society, such that all one can do is to try to make it more just, more tolerant, and so on. A simple but pertinent question arises here: if liberal-democratic capitalism obviously works better than all known alternatives, if liberal-democratic capitalism is, if not the best, then at least the least worst form of society, why do we not simply resign ourselves to it in a mature way, even accept it wholeheartedly? Why insist, against all hope, on the communist idea? Is such an insistence not an exemplary case of the narcissism of the lost cause? And does such narcissism not underlie the predominant attitude of academic Leftists who expect a theoretician to tell them what

lapses, have to exploit the window of opportunity, to seize power-which at that moment lies, as it were, in the street-and then fortify their hold on it, building up repressive apparatuses, and so forth, so that, once the moment of confusion is over and the majority sobers up only to be disappointed by the new regime, it is too late to reverse things, for the revolutionaries are now firmly entrenched.

The case of communist ex-Yugoslavia is typical here: throughout World War II, the communists ruthlessly hegemonized the resistance against the German occupying forces, monopolizing their role in the anti-fascist struggle by actively seeking to destroy al alternative ("bourgeois") resisting forces, while simultaneously denying the communist nature of their struggle (those who raised the suspicion that the communists planned to grab power and foment a revolution at the end of the war were swiftly denounced as spreading enemy propaganda). After the war, once they did indeed seize full power, things changed quickly and the regime openly displayed its true communist nature. The communists, although genuinely popular until around 1946, nonetheless cheated almost openly in the general election of that year. When asked why they had done so-since they could easily have won in a free election anyway-their answer (in private, of course) was that this was true, but then they would have lost the next election four years later, so it was better to make clear now what kind of election they were prepared to tolerate. In short, they were fully aware of the unique opportunity that had brought them to power. An awareness of the communists' historical failure to build and sustain genuine long-term hegemony based on popular support was thus, from the very beginning, taken into account.

Thus again, it is not enough simply to remain faithful to the communist Idea; one has to locate within historical reality antagonisms which give this Idea a practical urgency. The only true question today is: do we endorse

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the predominant naturalization of capitalism, or does today's global capitalism contain antagonisms which are sufficiently strong to prevent its indefinite reproduction? There are four such antagonisms: the looming threat of an ecological catastrophe; the inappropriateness of the notion of private property in relation to so-called "intellectual property" ; the socio-ethical implications of new techno-scientific developments (especially in biogenetics); and, last but not least, the creation of new forms of apartheid, new Walls and slums. There is a qualitative difference between this last feature-the gap that separates the Excluded from the Included-and the other three, which designate different aspects of what Hardt and Negri call the "commons;' the shared substance of our social being, the privatization of which involves violent acts which should, where necessary, be resisted with violent means:

-the commons of culture, the imediately socialized forms of "cognitive" capital, primarily language, our means of communication and education, but also the shared infrastructure of public transport, electricity, the postal system, and so on;

-the commons of external nature, threatened by pollution and exploitation (from oil to rain forests and the natural habitat itself);

-the commons of internal nature (the biogenetic inheritance of humanity); with new bioge

elerated developments) asymptotically approaching a zero-point at which the quantitative expansion will reach a limit and a qualitative change will then occur. The "spikes" are population growth, the consumption of finite resources, carbon gas emissions, and the mass extinction of species. In order to cope with these threats, the dominant ideology is mobilizing mechanisms of dissimulation and self-deception which include a will to ignorance: "a general pattern of behavior among threatened human societies is to become more blinkered, rather than more focused on the crisis, as they fail:' The same goes for the ongoing economic crisis: in late Spring 2009 it was successfully "renormalized" -the panic blew over, the situation was proclaimed as "getting better:' or at least the damage as having been controlled (the price paid for this "recovery" in the Third World countries was, of course, rarely mentioned)-thereby constituting an ominous warning that the true message of the crisis had been ignored, and that we could relax once again and continue our long march towards the apocalypse.
Apocalypse is characterized by a specific mode of time, clearly opposed to the two other predominant modes: traditional circular time (time ordered and regulated on cosmic principles, reflecting the order of nature and the heavens; the time-form in which microcosm and macrocosm resonate in harmony), and the modern linear time of

5
Ed Ayres, "Why are we not astonished;' World Watch, Vol. 12, May 1999.

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gradual progress or development. Apocalyptic time is the "time of the end of time;' the time of emergency, of the "state of exception" when the end is nigh and we can only prepare for it. There are at least four different versions of apocalyptism today: Christian fundamentalism, New Age spirituality, techno-digital post-humanism, and secular ecologism. Although they all share the basic notion that humanity is approaching a zero-point of radical transmutation, their respective ontologies differ radically: Techno-digital apocalyptism (of which Ray Kurzweil is the main representative) remains within the confines of scientific naturalism, and discerns in the evolution of human species the contours of our transformation into "post-humans." New Age spirituality gives this transmutation a further twist, interpreting it as the shift from one mode of "cosmic awareness" to another (usually a shift from the modern dualist-mechanistic stance to one of holistic immersion). Christian fundamentalists of course read the apocalypse in strictly biblical terms, that is, they search for (and find) in the contemporary world signs that the final battle between Christ and the Anti-Christ is imminent. Finally, secular ecologism shares the naturalist stance of post-humanism, but gives it a negative twist-what lies ahead, the "omega point" we are approaching, is not a progression to a higher "post-human" level, but the catastrophic self-destruction of humanity. Although Christian fundamentalist apocalyptism is considered the most ridiculous, and dangerous, in its content, it remains the version closest to a radical "milenarian" emancipatory logic. The task is thus to bring it into closer contact with secular ecologism, thereby conceiving the threat of annihilation as the chance for a radical emancipatory renewal.

Socialism or Communism?

Such apocalyptic proletarianization is,

ternal tension between subject and substance ("man" deprived of its substance) within the human collective. There are subjects who, within the human collective, directly embody the proletarian position of substanceless subjectivity. Which is why the Communist wager is that the only way to solve the "external" problem (the re-appropriation of alienated substance) is to radically transform the inner-subjective (social) relations.

It is thus crucial to insist on the communist-egalitarian emancipatory Idea, and insist on it in a very precise Marxian sense: there are social groups which, on account of their lacking a determinate place in the "private" order of the social hierarchy, stand directly for universality; they are what Ranciere calls the "part of no-part" of the social body. All truly emancipatory politics is generated by the short-circuit between the universality of the "public use of reason" and the universality of the "part of no-part" -this was already the communist dream of the young Marx: to bring together the universality of philosophy with the universality of the proletariat. From Ancient Greece, we have a name for the intrusion of the Excluded into the socio-political space: democracy. Our question today is whether democracy is still an appropriate name for this egalitarian explosion. Two extreme positions here are, on the one hand, the cursory dismissal of democracy as the mere

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illusory form of appearance of its opposite (class domination), and on the other the claim that the democracy we have, really existing democracy, is a distortion of true democracy-along the lines of Gandhi's famous reply to the British journalist who asked him about Western civilization: "A good idea. Perhaps we should put it into practice!"

Obviously, the debate which moves between these two extremes is too abstract: what we need to address is the question of how democracy relates to the dimension of universality embodied in the Excluded.

This focus on the walls that separate the Excluded from the Included may easily be misunderstood as a clandestine return to the liberal-tolerant-multicultural topic of "openness" ("no one should be left out, all minority groups, lifestyles, etc., should be allowed in") at the expense of a properly Marxist notion of social antagonism. It might also be criticized from the opposite "postmodern" perspective as marking a theoretical regression to a naive Excluded/Included opposition that ignores the complex "micro-political" apparatus of social control and regulation analyzed by Foucault. Peter Hallward makes a similar critical point in response to Badiou's notion of invisibility, of "counting-for-nothing;' of the symptomal element of the social edifice (Ranciere's "part of no-part"):

Practical political work is more often concerned with people or situations who are not so much invisible or unseen as under seen or mis-seen; they do not count for nothing so much as for very little. They are not simply excluded so much as oppressed and explOited.

This difference involves more than nuance. As several generations of emancipatory thinkers have now argued, modern forms of power do not primarily exclude or prohibit but rather modulate, gUide or enhance the behaviour and norms conducive to the status quo; the model of power that seems tacitly to inform Badiou's recent work, by contrast, still seems to pre-dat

ty sexualizes this controlling activity itself. Sexuality is thus, of course, not "invisible" -it is controlled and regulated. What is "invisible" is the sexualization of this very work of control: not the elusive object we try to control, but the mode of our own participation within it.

Liberals who acknowledge the problems of those excluded from the socio-political process formulate their goal as being the inclusion of those whose voices are not heard: al positions should be listened to, al interests taken into account, the human rights of everyone guaranteed, al ways of life, cultures and practises respected, and so on. The obsession of this democratic discourse is the protection of al kinds of minorities: cultural, religious, sexual, e tutti quanti. The formula of democracy is patient negotiation and compromise. What gets lost here is the proletarian position, the position of universality embodied in the Excluded. This is why, upon a closer look, it becomes clear that what Hugo Chavez has begun doing in Venezuela differs markedly from the standard liberal form of inclusion: Chavez is not including the excluded in a pre-existing liberal-democratic framework; he is, on the contrary, taking the "excluded" dwellers of favelas as his base and then reorganizing political space and political forms of organization so that the latter wil "fit" the excluded. Pedantic and abstract as it may appear, this difference-between "bourgeois democracy" and "dictatorship of the proletariat" -is crucial.

A century ago, Vilfredo Pareto was the first to describe the so-called

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80120 rule of social (and not only social) life: 80 percent of land is owned by 20 percent of the people, 80 percent of profits are produced by 20 percent of the employees, 80 percent of decisions are made during 20 percent of meeting time, 80 percent of the links on the Web point to less than 20 percent of Webpages, 80 percent of peas come from 20 percent of the peapods. As some social analysts and economists have suggested, the contemporary explosion of economic productivity confronts us with the ultimate case of this rule: the coming global economy will tend towards a state in which only 20 percent of the labor force are able to do all the necessary work, so that 80 percent of people will be baSically irrelevant and of no use, thus potentially unemployed. As this logic reaches its extreme, would it not be reasonable to bring it to its self-negation :  is not a system which renders 80 percent of people irrelevant and useless itself irrelevant and of no use?

Toni Negri once gave an interview to Le Monde during which, strolling along a suburban street in Venezia-Mestre with the journalist, he came across a line of workers picketing outside a textile factory. Pointing to the workers he dismissively remarked: "It's crazy, it's like a Fellini film!"IO For Negri, the workers stood for all that is wrong with traditional trade-unionist socialism focused on corporate job security, a socialism mercilessly rendered obsolete by the dynamics of "post-modern" capitalism and the hegemonic position of cognitive labor. According to Negri, instead of reacting to this "new spirit of capitalism" in the traditional social-democratic fashion, seeing it as a threat, one should fully embrace it, in order to discern within it-in the dynamics of cognitive labor with its non-hierarchical and non-centraliz

h is entrusted to him.1l
The paradox of Kant's formula "Think freely, but obey!" (which, of course, poses a series of problems of its own, since it also relies on the distinction between the "performative" level of social authority and the level of free thinking where performativity is suspended) is thus that one participates in the universal dimension of the "public" sphere precisely as a singular individual extracted from, or even opposed to, one's substantial communal identification-one is truly universal only when radically singular, in the interstices of communal identities. It is Kant who should be read here as the critic of Rorty. In his vision of public space characterized by the unconstrained exercise of Reason, he invokes a dimension of emancipatory universality outside the confines of one's social identity, of one's position within the order of (social) being-precisely the dimension so crucially missing in Rorty.
This space of singular universality is what, within Christianity, appears as the "Holy Spirit" -the space of a collective of believers subtracted from the field of organic communities, or of particular life-worlds ("neither Greeks nor Jews"). Consequently, is Kant's "Think freely, but obey!" not a new version of Christ's "Render therefore unto
11
Immanuel Kant, "What is Enlightenment?" in Isaac Kramnick (ed.), The Portable Enlightenment Reader, New York: Penguin Books 1995, p. 5.

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Caesar the things which are Caesar's; and unto God the things that are God's"? "Render unto Caesar the things which are Caesar's": in other words, respect and obey the "private" particular life-world of your community; "and unto God the things that are God's": in other words, participate in the universal space of the community of believers.
The Paulin ian collective of believers is a proto-model of the Kantian "world-civil-society;' and the domain of the state itself is thus in its own way "private": private in the precise Kantian sense of the "private use of Reason" in the State administrative and ideological apparatuses.
In his later Conflict of Faculties, Kant prolongs these reflections in addressing a simple but hard-to-answer question: is there true progress in history? (He meant ethical progress, not just material development.) He conceded that actual history is confused and allows for no clear proof on the matter (think for example of how the twentieth century brought an unprecedented expansion of democracy and welfare provision, but also the Holocaust and the Gulag . . . ), but he nonetheless concluded that, although progress cannot be proven, we can discern signs which do indicate that it is possible. Kant interpreted the French Revolution as one such sign, which pointed towards the possibility of freedom: the hitherto unthinkable happened, a whole people had fear-lessly asserted its freedom and equality. For Kant, even more important than the often bloody reality of the events in the streets of Paris was the enthusiasm those events gave rise to in the eyes of sympathetic observers all around Europe:
The recent Revolution of a people which is rich in spirit, may well either fail or succeed, accumulate misery and atrocity, it nevertheless arouses in the heart of all spectators (who are not themselves caught up in it) a taking of sides according to desires which borders on enthusiasm and which, since its very expression

Python's religious spoof
The Life of Brian, set in Palestine at the time of Christ: the leader of a Jewish revolutionary resistance organization passionately argues that the Romans have brought only misery to the Jews; when his followers remark that they have nonetheless introduced education, built roads, constructed irrigation, and so on, he triumphantly concludes: "All right, but apart from the sanitation, education, medicine, wine, public order, irrigation, roads, the fresh-water system and public health, what have the Romans ever done for us?" Do the latest proclamations by Obama not follow the same line? "I stand for a radical break with Bush's politics! OK, I pleaded for full support for Israel, for continuing the war on terror in Afghanistan and Pakistan, for refusing prosecutions against those who ordered torture, and so on, but I still stand for a radical break with Bush's politics!" Obama's inauguration speech concluded this process of "political self-cleansing"-which is why it was such a disappointment even for many left-liberals in the US. It was a well-crafted but weirdly anemic speech whose message to "all other peoples and governments who are watching today" was: "we are ready to lead once more"; "we will not apologize for our way oflife, nor will we waver in its defense."
During the election campaign, it was often noted that when Obama

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talked about the "audacity of hope:' about a change we can believe in, he relied on a rhetoric which lacked any specific content: to hope for what? To change what? Now things are a little clearer: Obama proposes a tactical change destined to reassert the fundamental goals of US politics: the defense of the American way oflife and a leading role internationally for the US. The US empire will be now more humane, and respectful of others; it will lead through dialogue, rather than through the brutal imposition of its will. If the Bush administration was the empire with a brutal face, now we shall have the empire with a human face-but it will be the same empire. In Obama's June 2009 speech in Cairo, in which he tried to reach out to the Muslim world, he formulated the debate in terms of the depoliticized dialogue of religions (not even of civilizations)-this was Obama at his politically-correct worst.
Nevertheless, such a pessimistic view falls short. The global situation is not only a harsh reality, it is also defined by its ideological contours, by what is visible and invisible within it, sayable and unsayable. Recall Ehud Barak's response to Gideon Levy for Haaretz, more than a decade ago, when he was asked what he would have done had he been born a Palestinian: "I would have joined a terrorist organization:' This statement had nothing whatsoever to do with endorsing terrorism-but it had everything to do with opening a space for a dialogue with the Palestinians. Remember Gorbachev launching the slogans of glasnost and perestroika-no matter how he "really meant" them, he unleashed an avalanche which changed the world. Or, to take a negative example: today, even those who oppose torture accept it as a topic of public debate-a major regression in our common discourse. Words are never "only words"; they matter because they define the contours of what we can do.
In this respect then, Obama has already demonstrated an extraordinary ability to change the limits of what one can say publicl

for subterranean solidarities that
have a chance of appealing to universal, moral sentiment, the source
today of enthusiasm and hope!O
Buck-Morss provides here a precise argument against the postmodern
poetry of diversity: the latter masks the underlying sameness of the brutal
violence enacted by culturally diverse cultures and regimes: "Can we rest
satisfied with the call for acknowledging 'multiple modernities: with a
politics of 'diversity: or 'multiversalit}!, when in fact the inhumanities of
these multiplicities are often strikingly the same?"21 But, one may ask,
was the ex -slaves' singing of the Marseillaise ultimately not an index of
colonialist subordination-even in their self-liberation, did not the Blacks
have to follow the emancipatory model of the colonial metropolis? And is
this not similar to the idea that contemporary opponents of US politics
should be singing the Stars and Stripes? Surely the true revolutionary act
would have been for the colonizers to sing the songs of the colonized?
The mistake in this reproach is double. First, contrary to appearances,
it is far more acceptable for the colonial power to see its own people
singing others' (the colonized's) songs than songs which express their
own identity-as a sign of tolerance and patronizing respect, colonizers
love to learn and sing the songs of the colonized . . . Second, and much
more importantly, the message of the Haitian soldiers' Marseillaise
was not "You see, even we, the primitive blacks, are able to assimilate
ourselves to your high culture and politics, to imitate it as a model!"
but a much more precise one: "in this battle, we are more French than
you, the Frenchmen, are-we stand for the innermost consequences
of your revolutionary ideology, the very consequences you were not
able to assume:' Such a message cannot but be deeply unsettling for the
20
Ibid . ? p. 133.
21
Ibid . ? p. 138 9.

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colonizers-and it would certainly not be the message of those who,
today, might sing the Stars and Stripes when confronting the US army.
(Although, as a thought experiment, if we imagine a situation in which
this could be the message, there would be nothing a priori problematic
in doing so.)
Once we fully integrate this message, we white Leftist men and
women are free to leave behind the politically correct process of
endless self-torturing guilt. Although Pascal Bruckner's critique of the
contemporary Left often approaches the absurd," this does not prevent
him from occasionally generating pertinent insights-one cannot but
agree with him when he detects in European politically correct self-
flagellation an inverted form of clinging to one's superiority. Whenever
the West is attacked, its first reaction is not aggressive defense but self-
probing: what did we do to deserve it? We are ultimately to be blamed
for the evils of the world; Third World catastrophes and terrorist
violence are merely reactions to our crimes. The positive form of the
White Man's Burden (his responsibility for civilizing the colonized
barbarians) is thus merely replaced by its negative form (the burden of
the white man's guilt) : if we can no longer be the benevolent masters
of the Third World, we can at least be the privileged source of evil,
patronizingly depriving others of responsibility for their fate (when
a Third World country engages in terrible crimes, it is never fully

ent barbarism of bourgeois civilization lies unveiled before
our eyes, turning from its home, where it assumes respectable forms, to
the colonies, where it goes naked:'>5 All Marx adds is that
England has broken down the entire framework of Indian society,
without any symptoms of reconstitution yet appearing. This loss of
his old world, with no gain of a new one, imparts a particular kind
of melancholy to the present misery of the Hindu, and separates
Hindustan, ruled by Britain, from all its ancient traditions, and from
the whole of its past history . . . . England, it is true, in causing a social
revolution in Hindustan, was actuated only by the vilest interests, and
was stupid in her manner of enforcing them. But that is not the question.
The question is, can mankind fulfil its destiny without a fundamental
revolution in the social state of Asia? If not, whatever may have been the
crimes of England she was the unconscious tool of history in bringing
about that revolution!6
One should not dismiss the talk of the "unconscious tool of history" as
the expression of a naive teleology, of trust in the Cunning of Reason
which makes even the vilest crimes instruments of progress -the point is
simply that the British colonization of India created the conditions for the
double liberation ofIndia: from the constraints of its own tradition as well
as from colonization itself. At a reception for Margaret Thatcher in 1985,
25
Karl Marx, "The Future Results of British Rule in India; in Surveys From Exile.
edited and introduced by David Fernbach, Harmondsworth: Penguin 1973, p. 324
26
Karl Marx, "The British Rule in India;' in ibid., pp. 302 3, 306 7.

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the Chinese president applied to China Marx's statement about the role of
British colonization in India: "The British occupation has awakened China
from its age-old sleep:" 7 Far from signaling continuous self-abasement in
front of the ex -colonial powers, statements like these express true "post-
postcolonialism;' namely, a mature independence: to admit the positive
effect of colonization, one has to be really free and be able to leave behind
its stigma. (And, symmetricaly, rejecting self-blame, while fully and-
why not-proudly claiming one's emancipatory heritage, is a sine qua non
for the renewal of the Left.)
Someone who cannot be accused of softness towards the colonizers
is Frantz Fanon: his thoughts on the emancipatory power of violence
are an embarrassment for many politically correct postcolonial
theorists. However, as a perspicuous thinker trained in psychoanalysis,
he also, back in 1952, provided the most poignant expression of the
refusal to capitalize on the guilt of the colonizers:
I am a man, and what I have to recapture is the whole past of the world.
I am not responsible solely for the slave revolt in Santo Domingo. Every
time a man has contributed to the victory of the dignity of the spirit,
every time a man has said no to an attempt to subjugate his fellows, I
have felt solidarity with his act. In no way does my basic vocation have
to be drawn from the past of peoples of color. In no way do I have
to dedicate myself to reviving a black civilization unjustly ignored. I
will not make myself the man of any past. . . . My black skin is not a
repository for specific values . . . . Haven't I got better things to do on
this earth than avenge the Blacks of the seventeenth century? .

forms of immigrant exclusion, and so on, we should always bear in mind that anti-immigration politics is not directly linked to capitalism or the interests of capital. The free circulation oflabor is, on the contrary, in the interests of big capital, since cheaper immigrant labor wil put pressure on "our own' workers to accept lower wages. And is outsourcing not also now an inverted form of employing immigrant workers? Resistance against immigrants is primarily the spontaneous -defensive reaction of the local working classes who (not wholly unjustifiably) perceive the immigrant worker as a new kind of strike-breaker and, as such, as an ally of capital. In short, it is global capital which is inherently multiculturalist and tolerant. The standard position adopted by the unconditional defenders of the rights of illegal immigrants is to concede that, at the level of state, the counter-arguments may well be "true" (Le., of course a country cannot accept an endless flow of immigrants; of course they compete in ways which threaten local jobs, and may also pose certain security risks), but their defense moves at a different level altogether, a level which has a direct link with demands of reality, the level of principled politicS where we can unconditionally insist that "qui est ici est d'ici" ("those who are here are from here'). But is this principled position not all too simple, allowing for the comfortable position of a beautiful soul? I insist on my principles, and let the state deal with pragmatic constraints of reality . . . In this way, do we not avoid a crucial aspect of the political battle for the rights

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of immigrants: how to convince the workers opposing those immigrants that they are fighting the wrong battle; and how to propose a feasible form of alternative politics? The "impossible" (an openness to immigrants) has to happen in reality-this would be a true political event.

But why should the immigrant not be satisfied with his normalization? Because, instead of asserting his identity, he has to adapt to his oppressor's standards: he is accepted, but de facto in a secondary role. His oppressor's discourse defines the terms of his identity. One should remember here the programmatic words of Stokely Carmichael (the founder of Black Power): "We have to fight for the right to invent the terms which will allow us to define ourselves and to define our relations to society, and we have to fight that these terms will be accepted. This is the first need of a free people, and this is also the first right refused by every oppressor:' The problem is how, exactly, to do this. That is to say, how to resist the temptation to define oneself with reference to some mythical and totally external identity ('?frican roots"), which, by way of cutting links with "white" culture, also deprives the oppressed of crucial intellectual tools for their struggle (namely, the egalitarian-emancipatory tradition) as well as potential allies. One should thus slightly correct Carmichael's words: what the oppressors really fear is not some totally mythical self-definition with no links to white culture, but a self-definition which, by way of appropriating key elements of the "white" egalitarian-emancipatory tradition, redefines that very tradition, transforming it not so much in terms of what it says as in what it does not say-that is, obliterating the i

t accepted, he started to preach the radically egali-
tarian doctrine of the Kharijites, according to which the most qualified
man should reign, even if he was an Abyssinian slave. No wonder, again,
that the official historians (such as Al-Tabari and Al-Masudi) noted only
the "vicious and brutal" character of the uprising . . .
But there is no need to go more than a thousand years back to find
this dimension of Islam-a glance at the events that followed the 2009
presidential election in Iran is sufficient. The green color adopted by
Mousavi supporters, the cries of "Allah akbar!" that resonated from the
roofs of Tehran in the evening darkness, dearly indicate that they saw
their mobilization as a repetition of the 1979 Khomeini revolution, as
the return to its roots, undoing the revolution's later corruption. This
return to the origins is not only programmatic; it even more concerns
the mode of activity of the crowds: the emphatic unity of the people,
their all-encompassing solidarity, creative self-organization, impro-
vising manners to articulate protest, the unique mixture of spontaneity
and discipline, like the ominous march of thousands in complete
silence. This was a genuine popular uprising of the disappointed parti-
sans of the Khomeini revolution. This is why one should compare the
events in Iran to the US intervention in Iraq: Iran provided a case of
genuine assertion of popular will as against the foreign imposition
of democracy in Iraq. And this is also why the events in Iran may be
read as a comment on the platitudes of Obama's Cairo speech which
focused on the dialogue between religions: we do not need the dialogue
between religions (between civilizations), we need a link of solidarity
between those who struggle for justice in Muslim countries and those

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who participate in the same struggle elsewhere. In other words, we
require a politicization process which strengthens the struggle here,
there and everywhere.
There are a couple of crucial consequences to be drawn from this
insight. First, Ahmadinejad is not the hero of the Islamist poor, but a
genuine corrupted Islamo-Fascist populist, a kind ofIranian Berlusconi
whose mixture of clownish posturing and ruthless power-politics
causes unease even among the majority of ayatollahs. His demagogic
distribution of crumbs to the poor should not deceive us: behind him
are not only organs of police repression and a very Westernized PR
apparatus, but also a strong new class of the rich, the result of the
regime's corruption (Iran's Revolutionary Guards are not a working
class militia, but a mega-corporation, the strongest center of wealth
in the country). Second, one should draw a clear difference between
the two main candidates opposed to Ahmadinejad, Mehdi Karroubi
and Mousavi. Karroubi effectively is a reformist, basically proposing
the Iranian version of clientalism, promising favors to all the partic-
ular groups. Mousavi is something entirely different: his name stands
for a genuine resuscitation of the popular dreams which sustained
the Khomeini revolution. Even if this dream was a utopia, one should
recognize in it the genuine utopia of the revolution itself. For the
1979 Khomeini revolution cannot be reduced to a hard line Islamist
takeover-it was so much more. Now is the time to remember the
incredible effervescence of the first year after the revolution, with the
breath

s of reversals that
characterize modern revolutions-the passage from the Jacobins to Napoleon, from the October Revolution to Stalin, from Mao's Cultural Revolution to Deng Xiaoping's capitalism. How are we to read this passage? Is the second phase (the Thermidor) the "truth" of the first revolutionary phase (as Marx sometimes seems to claim), or is it just that in each case the revolutionary evental series exhausted itself?
I claim here that the communist Idea persists: it survives the failures of its realization as a specter which returns again and again, in an endless persistence best captured in the already-quoted words from Beckett's Worstward Ho: "Try again. Fail again. Fail better:' This brings us to the crux of the matter. One of the mantras of the postmodern Left has been that we should finally leave behind the "Jacobin-Leninist" paradigm of centralized dictatorial power. But perhaps the time has now come to turn this mantra around and admit that a good dose of just that "Jacobin-Leninist" paradigm is precisely what the Left needs today. Now, more than ever, one should insist on what Badiou calls the "eternal" Idea of Communism, or the communist "invariants" -the "four fundamental concepts" at work from Plato through the medieval millenarian revolts and on to Jacobinism, Leninism and Maoism: strict egalitarian justice, disciplinary terror, political voluntarism, and trust in the people. This matrix is not "superseded" by any new postmodern or postindustrial or post-whatever-you-want dynamic. However, up until the present historical moment, this eternal Idea functioned as,

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precisely, a Platonic Idea which persisted, returning again and again after every defeat. What is missing today is-to put it in philosophico-theological terms-a privileged link of the Idea to a Singular historical moment ( in the same way that, in Christianity, the whole eternal divine edifice stands and falls with the contingent event of the birth and death of Christ).
There is something unique in today's constellation: many perspicuous analysts have noted that contemporary capitalism poses a problem to this logic of a resistance which persists. Brian Massumi, for example, has formulated clearly how contemporary capitalism overcame the logic of totalizing normality and adopted the logic of erratic excess.)) And one can supplement this analysis in many directions-the very process of subtracting oneself and creating "liberated territories" outside the domain of state has been reappropriated by capital. Exemplary of the logic of global capitalism are the so-called "Special Economic Zones": geographical regions within a (usually Third World) state with economic laws which are more liberal than the state's standard economic laws (allowing for, e.g., lower import and export taxes, the free flow of capital, the limitation or direct prohibition of trade unions, no minimum working day, and so on) in order to increase foreign investments. The name itself covers a whole range of more specific zone types: Free Trade Zones, Export Processing Zones, Free Zones, Industrial Estates, Free Ports, Urban Enterprise Zones, etc. With their unique combination of "openness" (as a free space partially exempt from state sovereignty) and closure (enforcement of working conditions unencumbered by legally guaranteed freedoms), which renders possible heightened levels of

h today more than ever
appears as an exception.
The true question here is: how is externality with regard to the state to be operationalized? Since the Cultural Revolution signals the failure of the attempt to destroy the state from within, to abolish the state, is the alternative then simply to accept the state as a fact, as the apparatus which takes care of "servicing the goods:' and to operate at a distance towards it (bombarding it with prescriptive proclamations and demands)? Or is it, more radically, that we should aim at a subtraction from the hegemonic field which, Simultaneously, violently intervenes into this field, reducing it to its occluded minimal difference? Such a subtraction is extremely violent, even more violent than destruction/purification: it is reduction to the minimal difference of part(s)/no-part, 1 and 0, groups and the proletariat. It is not only a subtraction of the subject from the hegemonic field, but a subtraction which violently affects this field itself, laying bare its true coordinates. Such a subtraction does not add a third position to the two positions whose tension characterizes the hegemonic field (so that we now have, along with liberalism and fundamentalism, a radical Leftist emancipatory politics). The third term rather "denaturalizes" the whole hegemonic field, bringing out the underlying complicity of the opposed poles that constitute it. Therein resides the dilemma of subtraction: is it a subtraction/

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withdrawal which leaves the field from which it withdraws intact (or which even functions as its inherent supplement, like the "subtraction" or withdrawal from social reality into one's true Self proposed by New Age meditation); or does it violently perturb the field from which it withdraws? "Subtraction" is thus what Kant called an amphibious concept. Paraphrasing Lenin, one can say that everything, up to and including the fate of radical emancipatory movements today, hinges on how we read this concept, on what word which will be attached to it or dissociated from it.
Badiou's "subtraction:' like Hegel's Aufhebung, contains three different layers of meaning: (1) to withdraw, disconnect; (2) to reduce the complexity of a situation to its minimal difference; (3) to destroy the existing order. As in Hegel, the solution is not to diferentiate the three meanings (eventually proposing a specific term for each of them), but to grasp subtraction as the unity of its three dimensions: one should withdraw from being immersed in a situation in such a way that the withdrawal renders visible the "minimal difference" sustaining the situation's multiplicity, and thereby causes its disintegration, just as the withdrawal of a single card from a house of cards causes the collapse of the entire edifice.
Of course, egalitarian-emancipatory "de-territorialization" is not the same as the postmodern-capitalist form, but it nonetheless radically changes the terms of the emancipatory struggle. In particular, the enemy is no longer the established hierarchical order of a state. How, then, are we to revolutionize an order whose very principle is constant self-revolutionizing? More than a solution to the problems we are facing today, communism is itself the name of a problem: a name for the difficult task of breaking out of the confines of the market-and-state framework, a task for which no quick formula is at ha

Opinion (1922), he wrote that a "governing
class" must rise to face the challenge-he saw the public as Plato did,
as a great beast or a bewildered herd, floundering in the "chaos oflocal
opinions:'J9 So the herd of citizens must be governed by "a specialized
class whose interests reach beyond the locality" -this elite class is to
act as a machinery of knowledge that circumvents the primary defect
of democracy, the impossible ideal of the "omni-competent citizen:'
This is indeed how our democracies function-and with our consent.
There is no mystery in what Lippmann was saying, it is an obvious fact;
the mystery is that, knowing this, we continue to play the game. We act
as if we are free to choose, while silently not only accepting but even
demanding that an invisible injunction (inscribed in the very form of
our commitment to "free speech") tells us what to do and to think. As
Marx noted long ago, the secret is in the form itself.
In this sense, in a democracy, every ordinary citizen is effectively
a king-but a king in a constitutional democracy, a monarch who
decides only formally, whose function is merely to sign off on measures
proposed by an executive administration. This is why the problem
with democratic rituals is homologous to the great problem of
constitutional monarchy: how to protect the dignity of the king? How
to maintain the appearance that the king effectively makes decisions,
when we all know this not to be true? Trotsky was thus right in his
basic reproach to parliamentary democracy, which was not that it gives
39
Walter Lippman, Public Opinionn, Charleston: BiblioLife 2008.

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too much power to the uneducated masses, but, paradoxically, that it
passivizes the masses, leaving the initiative with the apparatus of state
power (in contrast to the "soviets" in which the working classes directly
mobilize themselves and exert power). 40 What we refer to as the "crisis of
democracy" occurs not, therefore, when people stop believing in their
own power, but, on the contrary, when they stop trusting the elites,
those who are supposed to know for them and provide the guidelines,
when they experience the anxiety accompanying the recognition that
"the (true) throne is empty:' that the decision is now really theirs. This
is why in "free elections" there is always a minimal aspect of politeness:
those in power politely pretend that they do not really hold power, and
ask us to decide freely if we want to give them power-in a way which
mirrors the logic of a gesture meant to be refused.
To put it in the terms of the Will: representative democracy in its
very notion involves a passivization of the popular Will, its trans-
formation into non-willing-willing is transferred onto an agent
which re-presents the people and wills on its account. Whenever one
is accused of undermining democracy, one's answer should thus be a
paraphrase of the reply given by Marx and Engels to a similar reproach
(that communism undermines the family, property, freedom, etc.) in
The Communist Manifesto: the ruling order is itself already doing all
the undermining necessary. In the same way that (market) freedom
is un freedom for those who sell their labor-power, in the same way
that the family is undermined by the bourgeois family as legalized
prostitution, democracy is undermined by the parliamentary form
with its concomitant passivization of the large major

"spontaneous capitalist ideology:' attributing the success or failure of a businessman to some mysterious je ne sais quai he possessed. And does not the same hold true even more so today, as the abstraction of the market relations that govern our lives is pushed to an extreme pOint? The bookshops are overflowing with psychological manuals advising us on how to succeed, how to outdo our partner or competitor-in short, treating success as being dependent on the proper "attitude:' So, in a way, one is tempted to turn Marx's formula on its head: under contemporary capitalism, the objective market "relations between things" tend to asswne the phantasmagorical form of pseudo-personalized "relations between people:' And Hardt and Negri seem to fall into this trap: what they celebrate as the direct "production oflife" is a structural illusion of this type.

However, before we succumb to bemoaning the "alienating" effect of the fact that "relations between persons" are replaced by "relations between things" we should nonetheless keep in mind the opposite, liberating, effect: the displacement of the fetishism onto "relations between things" de-fetishizes "relations between persons:' allowing them to acquire "formal" freedom and autonomy. While, in a market economy, I remain de facto dependent, this dependency is nonetheless "civilized:' enacted in the form of a "free" market exchange between me and other persons instead of in the form of direct servitude or physical coercion. It is easy to ridicule Ayn Rand, but there is a grain of truth in the famous "hymn to money" from her Atlas Shrugged:

Until and unless you discover that money is the root of all good, you ask for your own destruction. When money ceases to become the means by

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which men deal with one another, then men become the tools of other men. Blood, whips and guns or dollars. Take your choice-there is no other.49

Does not Marx's formula regarding how, in a commodity economy, "relations between people assume the guise of relations among things" say something similar? In the market economy, relations between people can appear as relations of mutually recognized freedom and equality: domination is no longer directly enacted or visible as such. What is problematic is Rand's underlying premise: that the only choice is between direct and indirect relations of domination and exploitation.

So what about the standard critique of "formal freedom': namely that it is in a way even worse than direct servitude, since the forme r i s a mask that deludes one into thinking that one i s free? Th e reply to this critical point is provided by Herbert Marcuse's old motto that "freedom is the condition of liberation" : in order to demand "actual freedom;' I have to have already experienced myself as basically and essentiaily free-only as such can I experience my actual servitude as a corruption of my human condition. In order to experience this antagonism between my freedom and the actuality of my servitude, however, I have to be recognized as formally free: the demand for my actual freedom can only arise out of my "formal" freedom. In other words, in exactly the same way as, in the development of capitalism, the formal subsumption of the production process under Capital precedes its material subsumption, formal freedom precedes actual freedom, creating the latter's conditions. The very force of abst

, conditions which are no longer "spontaneously"
generated by the market. Perhaps therein resides the fundamental
"contradiction" of today's "postmodern" capitalism: while its logic
is de-regulatory, "anti-statal;' nomadic, deterritorializing, and so on,
its key tendency to the "becoming-rent-of-profit" signals a strength-
ening of the role of the state whose regulatory function is ever more
omnipresent. Dynamic deterritorialization co-exists with, and relies
on, increasingly authoritarian interventions of the state and its legal
and other apparatuses. What one can discern at the horizon of our
historical becoming is thus a society in which personal libertarianism
and hedonism co-exist with (and are sustained by) a complex web of
regulatory state mechanisms. Far from disappearing, the state is today
gathering strength.
To put it another way: when, due to the crucial role of the "general
intellect" (knowledge and social cooperation) in the creation of wealth,
forms of wealth are increasingly "out of all proportion to the direct
labour time spent on their production;' the result is not, as Marx
seems to have expected, the self-dissolution of capitalism, but rather
the gradual relative transformation of the profit generated by the
51 See Capitalismo cognitivo, edited by Carlo Vercellone, Rome: Manifestolibri 2006.

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exploitation of labor-power into rent appropriated by the privatization
of this very "general intellect:' Take the case of Bill Gates: how did he
become the richest man in the world? His wealth has nothing to do
with the cost of producing the commodities Microsoft sells (one can
even argue that Microsoft pays its intellectual workers a relatively high
salary). It is not the result of his producing good software at lower prices
than his competitors, or of higher levels of "exploitation" of his hired
workers. If this were the case, Microsoft would have gone bankrupt
long ago: masses of people would have chosen programs like Linux,
which are both free and, according to the specialists, better than Micro-
soft's. Why, then, are millions still buying Microsoft? Because Microsoft
has succeeded in imposing itself as an almost universal standard,
(virtually) monopolizing the field, in a kind of direct embodiment of
the "general intellect:' Gates became the richest man on Earth within
a couple of decades by appropriating the rent received from allowing
millions of intellectual workers to participate in that particular form
of the "general intellect" he successfully privatized and still controls. Is
it true, then, that today's intellectual workers are no longer separated
from the objective conditions of their labor (they own their PC, etc.),
which is Marx's description of capitalist "alienation"? Superficially,
one might be tempted to answer "yes;' but, more fundamentally, they
remain cut off from the social field of their work, from the "general
intellect;' because the latter is mediated by private capital.
And the same goes for natural resources: their exploitation is one
of the great sources of rent today, marked by a permanent struggle
over who is to receive this rent, the peoples of the Third World or
Western corporations. The supreme irony is that, in order to explain the
difference between labor-power (which, when put to work, produces
surplus-value over and above its own value) and other commodities
(the value of which is

rms of the choice, but
not the choice itself. At each moment of time, there are multiple
possibilities waiting to be realized; once one of them is actualized,
others are cancelled. The supreme case of such an agent of historical
time is the Leibnizian God who created the best possible world: before
creation, he had in mind the entire panoply of possible worlds, and
his decision consisted in choosing the best among these options. Here,
possibility precedes choice: the choice is a choice among possibilities.
Even this notion of "open" history, however, is inadequate. What is
unthinkable within this horizon of linear historical evolution is the
notion of a choice or act which retroactively opens up its own possi-
bility: the idea that the emergence of the radically New retroactively
changes the past-not the actual past of course (we are not in science
fiction), but past possibilities (or, to put it in more formal terms, the
value of modal propositions about the past). I have referred elsewhere
to Jean-Pierre Dupuy's claim that, if we are to confront adequately the
threat of (social or environmental) catastrophe, we need to break out of
this "historical" notion of temporality: we have to introduce a new notion
of time. Dupuy calls this time the "time of a project;' of a closed circuit
between the past and the future: the future is causally produced by our acts
in the past, while the way we act is determined by our anticipation of the
future and our reaction to this anticipation:
The catastrophic event is inscribed into the future as destiny, for sure,
but also as a contingent accident: it could not have taken place, even if,
in futur anterieur, it appears as necessary . . . . if an outstanding event
takes place, a catastrophe, for example, it could not not have taken
place; nonetheless, insofar as it did not take place, it is not inevitable.
It is thus the event's actualization-the fact that it takes place
which
retroactively creates its necessity. 53
53
Jean Pierre Dupuy, Petite metaphysique des tsunami, Paris: Seuil 2oo5, p. 19.

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If-accidentally-an event takes place, it creates the preceding chain
which makes it appear inevitable: this, and not commonplaces on how
underlying necessity expresses itself in and through the accidental
play of appearances, is in nuce the Hegelian dialectic of contingency
and necessity. In this sense, although we are determined by destiny,
we are nonetheless free to choose our destiny. According to Dupuy, this
is also how we should approach the ecological crisis: not to appraise
"realistically" the possibilities of catastrophe, but to accept it as Destiny
in the precise Hegelian sense-if the catastrophe happens, one can say
that its occurrence was decided even before it took place. Destiny and
free action (to block the "if") thus go hand in hand: at its most radical,
freedom is the freedom to change one's Destiny.
This, then, is how Dupuy proposes to confront the disaster: we
should first perceive it as our fate, as unavoidable, and then, projecting
ourselves into it, adopting its standpoint, we should retroactively insert
into its past (the past of the future) counterfactual possibilities ("If
we had done this and that, the calamity that we are now experiencing
would not have occurred!") upon which we then act today. We have to
accept that, at the level of possibilities, our future is doomed, that the
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ch-hunt, and warned that in using
such methods to fight Stalinism the US only risked becoming more like its opponent. He also become increasingly aware of the injustices of the liberal democracies, and his desire to see changes in Western society developed almost into an obsession. After writing a much less popular sequel to his I Chose Freedom, significantly entitled I Chose Justice, Kravchenko set out on a crusade to find a new, less exploitative, mode of organizing production. This led him to Bolivia, where he ploughed his money into organizing poor farmers into new collectives. Crushed by the failure of these endeavors, he withdrew into solitude and eventually shot himself at his home in New York. His suicide was the consequence of his despair, not the result of some KGB blackmail-proof that his denunciation of the Soviet Union had been a genuine act of protest against injustice.

Today, new Kravchenkos are emerging everywhere, from the US to India, China and Japan, from Latin America to Africa, the Middle East to Western and Eastern Europe. They are disparate and speak different languages, but they are not as few as may appear-and the greatest fear of the rulers is that these voices will start to reverberate and reinforce each other in solidarity. Aware that the odds are pulling us towards catastrophe, these actors are ready to act against all odds. DisappOinted by twentieth-century Communism, they are ready to "begin from the beginning" and reinvent it on a new basis. Decried by enemies as dangerous utopians, they are the only people who have really awakened from the utopian dream which holds most of us under its sway. They, not those nostalgics for twentieth-century "Really Existing Socialism;' are our only hope.

The fact that Deleuze, just before he died, was in the middle of writing a book on Marx, is indicative of a wider trend. In the Christian past, it was common for people who had led dissolute lives to return

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to the safe haven of the church in old age, so they might die reconciled with God. Something similar is happening today with many anti-communist Leftists. In their final years, they return to communism as if, after their life of depraved betrayal, they want to die reconciled with the communist Idea. As with the old Christians, these late conversions carry the same basic message: that we have spent our lives rebelling vainly against what, deep within us, we knew all the time to be the truth. So, when even a great anti-communist like Kravchenko can in a certain sense return to his faith, our message today should be: do not be afraid, join us, come back! You've had your anti-communist fun, and you are pardoned for it-time to get serious once again!